

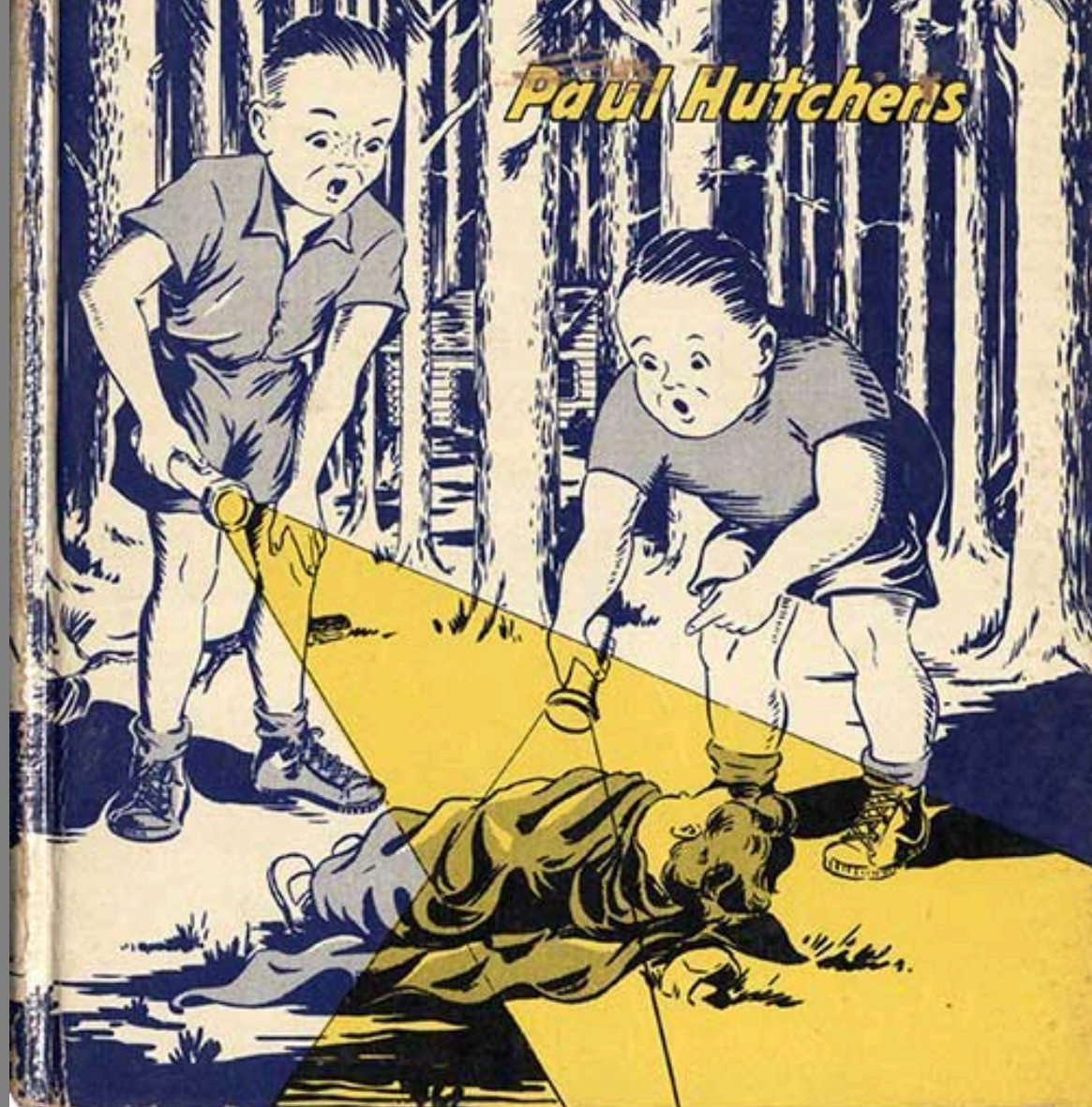
THE SUGAR CREEK GANG GOES NORTH

Paul Hutchens



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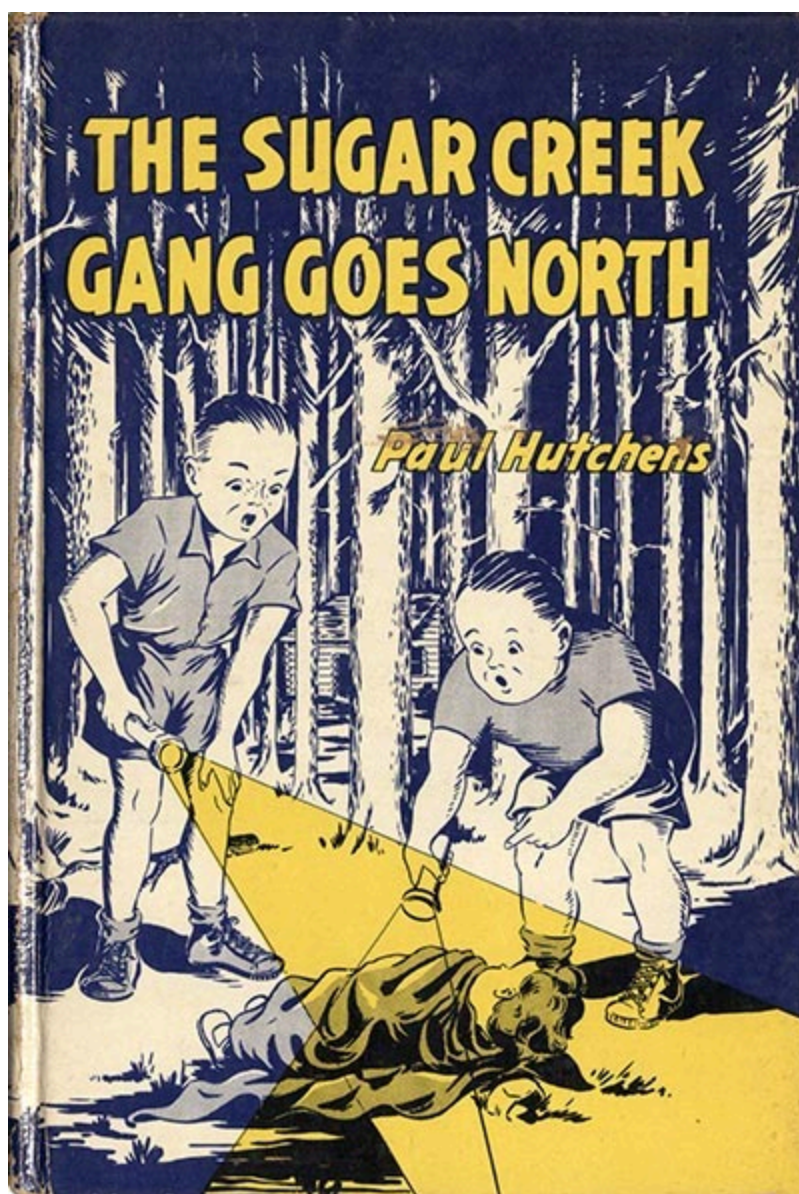
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*THE SUGAR CREEK GANG
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by

PAUL HUTCHENS



Published by

Scripture Press

BOOK DIVISION

434 South Wabash Ave.

Chicago 5, Ill.

[See autographed copy.](#)

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1

I GUESS I never did get tired thinking about all the interesting and exciting things which had happened to the Sugar Creek Gang when we'd gone camping far up in the North. One of the happiest memories was of the time when Poetry, who is the barrel-shaped member of our gang, and I were lost out in the forest, and while we were trying to get unlost we met a very cute little brown-faced Indian boy whose name was Snow-in-the-face, and his big Indian brother whose name was Eagle Eye.

Little Snow-in-the-face was really the cutest little Indian boy I had ever seen; in fact, he was the first one I'd ever really seen up real close. I kept thinking about him and wishing that the whole Sugar Creek Gang could go again up into that wonderful country which everybody calls the Paul Bunyan Playground and see how Little Snow-in-the-face was getting along, and how his big brother's Indian Sunday school was growing, which, as you know, they were having every Sunday in an old railroad coach, which they'd taken out into the forest and fixed up into a church. Say, I never had any idea that we would get to go back so soon, in fact, the very next summer after we'd been there the summer before.

But here I go telling you about how we happened to get to go, and how quick we started, and all the exciting things that happened on the way and after we got there, and especially *after* we got there. Boy oh boy! it was real fun, and also very exciting—especially that night when we ran kersmack into a kidnapper mystery, and some of us who were mixed up in it were almost half scared half to death. Imagine a very dark night with only moonlight enough to make things look spooky, and queer screaming sounds echoing through the forest and over the lake, and then finding the kidnapped girl all wrapped in an Indian blanket with a handkerchief stuffed into her mouth and—but that's getting ahead of the story, and I'd better not tell you how it happened until I get to it, 'cause it might spoil the story for

you, and I hope you won't start turning the pages of this book real fast and read the mystery first, 'cause that wouldn't be fair.... Don't you dare skip even one page. You just keep reading along until you get there.

Anyway, this is how we were going to get to go. Some of the Sugar Creek Gang of us were lying in the long mashed-down grass, in a level place at the top of the steep incline not very far from where the hill goes down real steep to the spring at the bottom where my pop is always sending me to get a pail of real cold fresh water for us to drink at our house. We were all of us lying in different directions, talking and laughing and yawning and pretending to be sleepy, also some of us were tumbling around a little and making a nuisance of ourselves to each other. Most of us had long stems of blue grass in our mouths and were chewing on the ends, and all of us were feeling swell. I had my binoculars in my hand and up to my eyes looking around at different things.

First, I watched a red squirrel, high up in a big sugar tree, lying flat and lazy on the top of a gray branch like he was taking a two-o'clock-in-the-afternoon sun bath, which was what time of day it was that Saturday afternoon. I had been lying on my back, looking up at the squirrel, then I rolled over and got onto my knees and focused the binoculars on Sugar Creek. Sugar Creek's face was very lazy, on account of that being a wide part of the creek, and the water moved very slowly, hardly moving, and was as quiet as Pass Lake had been up in Minnesota in the Paul Bunyan country, on a very quiet day. There were little whitish patches of different shaped specks of white foam floating along on the kinda brownish blue water. While I was looking at Sugar Creek with its big wide quiet face, and dreaming about a big blue-watered lake up North, I saw some V-shaped waves coming out across the creek from the opposite shore. The sharp-pointed end of the V was coming straight toward the spring and bringing the rest of the V along with it. I knew right away it was a muskrat and it was swimming right straight toward our side of the creek. Looking at the brownish muskrat with the binoculars made it seem like it was very close, and I could see its pretty chestnut brown fur. Its head was broad and kinda blunt, and I knew if I could have seen its tail it would have been about half as long as the muskrat, and deeper than it was wide, and that it would have scales on it, and only a few scattered hairs. I quick grabbed a big rock and

quick threw that rock as straight as I could and as hard, right straight toward the acute angle of the long moving V which was still coming across the creek toward us.

And would you believe it? I'm not always such a good shot with a rock, but this time that rock went straight toward where the muskrat was headed for, and by the time the rock and the muskrat got to the same place at the same time, the rock went kerswishety-splash right on the broad blunt head of the *musquash*, which is another and kinda fancy name for a muskrat.

Circus, the acrobat in our gang, was the only one of the gang who saw me do what I had done. He yelled out to me in a voice that sounded like a circus-barker's voice, "Atta boy, Bill! Boy oh boy, that was a swell shot! I couldn't have done any better myself!"

"Better than *what*?" nearly all the rest of the gang woke up and asked him at the same time.

"Bill killed an *Ondatra zibethica*," Circus said, which is the Latin name for a muskrat,—Circus' pop being a trapper, and Circus having a good animal book in his library. "Socked it in the head with a rock."

Everybody looked out toward Sugar Creek to the place where the rock had socked the *Ondatra* in the head, and where the two forks of the V were getting wider and wider, almost disappearing into nothing like waves do when they get old enough.

"Look at those waves!" Poetry said, meaning the new waves my big rock had started. There was a widening circle going out from where it had been struck.

"Reminds me of the waves of Pass Lake, where we spent our vacation last summer," Poetry said. "Remember the ones we had the tilt-a-whirl ride on, when Eagle Eye's boat upset, and we got separated from it, and if we hadn't had our life vests on we'd have been drowned 'cause it was too far from the shore to swim!"

“Sure,” Dragonfly piped up and said, “and that’s the reason why every boy in the world who is in a boat or a canoe on a lake or a river ought to wear a life vest, or else there ought to be plenty of life preservers in the boat or the canoe, just in case.”

“Hey!” Little Jim piped up and squeaked in his mouse-like voice. “Your On-onda-something or other has come to life away down the creek!” And sure enough, it had, for away down the creek, maybe fifty feet further, there was another V moving along toward the Sugar Creek bridge, which meant I hadn’t killed the *musquash* at all, but only scared it, and maybe my rock hadn’t even hit it at all, and it had ducked and swum under water like *Ondatra zibethicas* do in Sugar Creek and like loons do in Pass Lake in northern Minnesota.

“I’m thirsty,” Circus said, and jumped up from where he had been lying on his back with his feet propped up on a big hollow stump. That hollow stump was the same one, I thought, where his pop had slipped down inside once and had gotten bit by a black widow spider which had had her web inside.

Right away we were all of us scurrying down the steep hill to the spring and getting a drink apiece of water, either stooping down and drinking like cows or else using the paper cups which we had in a little container on the leaning tree that leaned over the spring and which we’d put there, instead of the old tin cup which we’d battered into a flat piece of tin and thrown into Sugar Creek.

All of a sudden, we heard a strange noise up at the top of the hill, and it sounded like somebody moving along through last year’s dead leaves and at the same time talking or mumbling to himself about something.

“Sh!” Dragonfly said, shushing us, he being the one who nearly always heard or saw something before any of the rest of us did.

We all hushed, and sure enough I heard it. It was a man’s voice, and he was talking to himself or something up there at the top of the hill.

“Sh!” I said to different ones of us, and we all stopped whatever we had been doing or saying, and didn’t move, all except Little Jim who lost his balance, and to keep from falling the wrong direction which was in a puddle of cold clean water on the other side of the spring, he had to step awkwardly in several places, jumping from one rock to another and using his pretty stick-candy-looking stick to help him.

We kept hushed for a jiffy and the sound up at the top of the hill kept right on—leaves rasping and rustling, and a man’s voice mumbling something like he was talking to himself.

All of us had our eyes on Big Jim, our leader. I was looking at his fuzzy mustache, which was like the down on a baby pigeon, and was wondering who was up at the top of the hill, and thinking about how I wished I could get a little fuzz on my upper lip, and wondering if I could make mine grow if I used some kind of cold cream on it, or something like girls do when they want to look more like older girls than they are.

Big Jim looked around at the irregular circle of us and nodded to me and motioned with his thumb for me to follow him up the hill. He stopped all the rest of the gang from following. In a jiffy, I was creeping quietly up that steep incline behind Big Jim, and also Little Jim came along, ’cause right at the last second Big Jim motioned to him that he could, on account of he had a hurt look in his eyes like maybe nobody thought he was important ’cause he was so little.

I had a trembling feeling all inside of me ’cause I just knew there was going to be a surprise at the top of that hill, and maybe a mystery. Also, I felt proud that Big Jim had picked me out to go up with him, on account of he nearly always picks Circus who is next biggest in the gang. I didn’t need to feel proud though, ’cause when I heard a little slithering noise behind me while I was on the way up, I knew why Circus didn’t get invited, and it was ’cause he was already half way up a small sapling which grew near the spring. He was already almost high enough to see what was going on at the top of the hill, Circus doing like he is always doing anyway, which is climbing trees most any time or all the time, he looking like a monkey even when he isn’t up a tree. The only thing that kept him from hanging by his

tail like a monkey was that he didn't have any tail, but he could hang by his legs anyway.

When we had almost reached the top, I felt Little Jim's small hand take hold of my arm tight, like he was scared, 'cause we could still hear somebody walking around and talking to himself.

Big Jim stopped us, and we all very slowly half-crawled the rest of the way up. My heart was pounding like everything, 'cause I just knew there was going to be excitement at the top, and when you know there is going to be excitement, you can't wait for it, but get excited right away.

"Listen!" Little Jim whispered to me beside me. "He's pounding something."

"Sh!" Big Jim said to us, frowning fiercely, and we kept still. What on earth was going on up there? I wondered, and wished I was a little farther up, but Big Jim had stopped us again, so we could listen.

One, two, three—pound, pound, pound... There were about nine or ten socks with something on something and then the pounding stopped and we heard footsteps going away.

I looked back down the hill at the rest of the gang. Dragonfly's eyes were large and round, like they are when he is half scared or excited; Poetry had a scowl on his fat face, he being one who has a detective-like mind and was maybe disappointed that Big Jim had made him stay at the bottom of the hill; little red-haired Tom Till's very freckled face looked very queer. He was stooped over trying to pry a root loose out of the ground, so he'd be ready to throw it at somebody or something, if he got a chance or if he had to, and his face looked like he was ready for some kind of fight, and like he half hoped there might be one. And if I had been down there at the bottom of the incline at the spring, and somebody else had been looking down at me, he would have seen another red-haired freckle-faced boy whose hair was trying to stand up on end under his old straw hat, and who wasn't much to look at, but who had a fiery temper which had to be watched all the time or it would explode on somebody or something.

Maybe in case you've never read anything about the Sugar Creek Gang before, I'd better tell you that I *am* red-haired and freckle-faced and do have a fiery temper some of the time, and that my name is Bill Collins. I have a swell mom and pop and a baby sister whose name is Little Charlotte Ann, and I'm the only boy in the Collins family. Not having any older sisters, I have to wash or wipe the dishes two or three times a day and help with some of the other girls' chores around our house, which maybe is good for me, Pop says, on account of when I wash dishes the hot sudsy water helps to keep my hands and fingernails clean.

I whirled around quick from looking down the hill at the rest of the gang and from seeing Circus who was up the elm sapling trying to see over the crest of the hill, but probably couldn't. Big Jim had his finger up to his pursed lips for all of us to keep on keeping still, which we did.

The pounding had stopped and we could hear footsteps moving along in the woods, getting fainter and fainter, and just that second Big Jim said to us, "He can't hear us now. His shoes are making so much noise in the leaves."

We all got to the top in a jiffy, and looked, and Little Jim whispered "It's somebody wearing old overalls," which it was, and he was disappearing around the corner of the path that led from the spring down the creek going toward the old sycamore tree and the swamp.

A few jiffies later, Big Jim gave us the signal and all of us broke out of our very painful silence and were acting like ourselves again, but wondering who on earth had been there and what he had been doing, and why, when all of a sudden, Dragonfly who had been looking around with Poetry, looking for shoe tracks, let out a yell and said, "Hey, Gang, come here! Here's a letter, nailed onto the old Black Widow Stump!" which is the name we'd given the stump after Circus' Pop had been bitten there.

We all made a rush to where Dragonfly's dragonfly-like eyes were studying something on the stump, and in a jiffy I was reading the envelope, and it said on it, in a very awkward old handwriting,

U R G E N T
To the Sugar Creek Gang
(Personal. Please open at once.)

2

WELL sir, I just stood there with all the rest of the members of the Sugar Creek Gang, staring and staring at the envelope and the crazy old handwriting on it that said, “Personal. Please Open at once.”

Big Jim, who, as you already know, is the leader of our gang, reached out and tore the envelope off the nail which had been driven through the envelope’s upper right-hand corner where the stamp would have been if there had been one, and handed it to me. “Read it out loud to all of us,” he said to me.

I couldn’t imagine what was on the inside. I didn’t recognize the handwriting, and couldn’t even guess who had written it.

“Stand back, everybody,” Big Jim ordered. “And let him have plenty of room.”

“Yeah, let him have plenty of room. It might explode,” Dragonfly said. I tore open the envelope in a hurry, and this is what I read:

“Members of the Sugar Creek Gang—Big Jim, Little Jim, Poetry, Circus, Dragonfly, Bill Collins, and Tom Till—as soon as you can, after reading this, make a beeline for Bumblebee Hill, climb through the barbed-wire fence at the top and stop at the tombstone of Sarah Paddler in the old abandoned cemetery. There you will find another letter giving you instructions what to do next. It is VERY IMPORTANT.

Signed ... (Guess Who)”

I read the letter out loud in a sort of trembling voice on account of I was a little bit scared, then I looked around at the different ones of us to see what we were thinking, but couldn't tell.

"What'll we do?" Little Jim piped up and said, and Little Tom Till swallowed real hard like he had taken too big a bite of something and was trying to swallow it without having chewed it long enough, then he sort of stuttered, "M-maybe a g-ghost wrote it."

I looked quick at Dragonfly on account of he believes there is such a thing as a ghost on account his mother thinks there is such a thing, and right away he had a funny expression on his face. Dragonfly's dragonfly-like eyes looked like they were even larger than they were. "My mother told me to stay out of that cemetery."

"Aw, fraidy cat," Poetry said, "there isn't any such thing as a ghost. Besides, ghosts can't write."

"Oh yes, they can!" Dragonfly said. "I saw it in the newspaper once that a senator or something's speech was written by a ghost writer and—"

"It's *crazy!*" Poetry said. "A ghost writer is somebody nobody knows who writes something for somebody and nobody knows it, but it's a real person and not a ghost, which isn't."

It sounded crazy, but Poetry read an awful lot of the many books his pop and mom were always buying for him, and he was as smart as anything.

Little Tom spoke up then and said, "A ghost wouldn't know that Bumblebee Hill had had its name changed from Strawberry Hill to Bumblebee Hill, would it?" And right away I was remembering that hill, where the gang had had a fierce fight with a town gang when Little Tom had still belonged to that other gang, and we had all of us stirred up a bumblebee's nest on that hillside and gotten stung in different places, which had hurt worse than each other's fists had, and the fight had broken up, and we'd given that hill a new name. In that fight as you maybe know, two red-haired boys had had a terrible battle and one of the red-haired freckled-faced boys had licked the other one all to smithereens for awhile, until I had

started fighting a little harder and then I'd licked him even worse, all in the same fight.

Big Jim spoke up then and said, "A ghost probably couldn't spell our names. Anyway, let's get going to the old cemetery and see what happens."

With that, Circus was already on his way, running like a deer, with all of us right at his heels as fast as we could go. Talking about spelling must have reminded Poetry of a poem, for, as you know, he was always learning new poems by heart and quoting them to us, he knowing maybe a hundred of them, and you never knew when he was going to start one of them at the wrong time. He hardly ever got to finish one, though, on account of the gang's stopping him, or else it was too long to finish it before we all thought of something we all'd rather do than listen to his poem.

Anyway, while he and I were puffing along with the rest of the gang toward Bumblebee Hill, he started in puffing out a new one I'd never heard before, and this is the way it went:

"The teacher has no E Z time
To teach his A, B, C's:
It per C V rance takes sublime,
And all his N R G's.
In K C doesn't use the birch
All kindness does S A,
The scholars who X L at church,
In school will ½ to pay ..."

"Don't use the word *birch*," I panted to Poetry, and he panted back at me, "Why?"

"'Cause it reminds me of *beech*, and *beech* reminds me of a beech switch which reminds me of a schoolteacher and that reminds me of school, and _____"

Poetry cut in on my sentence and said, “*Birch* reminds me of a birch tree away up North where we were on our camping trip once, and where I’d like to go again this year. In fact, it’s getting so hot that I don’t see how we can stand not going up there again.”

I looked out of the corner of my right eye at him as we dashed along behind and beside and in front of the gang toward Bumblebee Hill, and said, “I don’t see why we have to stay where it is so hot ALL summer.”

That started him off on his poem again and he get another whole verse in before we reached the bottom of Bumblebee Hill, and had to have most of our wind for climbing and not much for talking. This is the next verse which he puffed out to me, the poem still talking about a schoolteacher and was:

“They can’t C Y he makes them learn
L S N and his rules,
They C K chance to overturn,
Preferring 2B fools.”

I found out later how to spell out the poem when he showed it to me in his mother’s old scrapbook. It was a clever poem, I thought.

Puff, puff, puff, up the hill we went, and at the cemetery stopped. It was a real spooky place, all overgrown with weeds, and choke-berry, and blue vervain, and mullein stalks, the blue vervain being one of the very prettiest wild flowers in all Sugar Creek territory, but which all the farmers called a weed, and which maybe it was. But up real close and under a magnifying glass its flowers are very pretty. Just as I was climbing through the fence beside Little Jim, holding two strands of barbed wire far enough apart for him to slither through and not get his nice pretty new blue shirt caught, Little Jim, who is a sort of a dreamer and is always imagining what something or other looks like, said to me, “They look like upside down candelabrams, don’t they?” Little Jim knew I liked flowers myself, on account of my mom liked them so well, and always wanted me to pick some and set them in vases in different parts of our house.

“What looks like what?” Dragonfly said, and sneezed, and I knew right away that he was allergic to something in the cemetery, he being that way about nearly everything in Sugar Creek in the summertime, and when people are allergic to things like that, they nearly always sneeze a lot.

Little Jim finished getting through without getting his shirt caught and said, “The flower spikes which branch off from the stem of the vervain look like upside down candelabrum,” and I remembered that his mother, besides being the best pianist in all Sugar Creek territory, and taught piano and was maybe the prettiest mom of all the Sugar Creek’s Gang’s moms, also had all kinds of flowers in a special flower garden at their home, and she talked flowers so much that Little Jim probably knew all the different kinds of words that people use when they talk flowers.

Little Jim broke off a stalk of vervain, and I noticed that there was a little purplish ring of small flowers at the very bottom of every one of the very slender flower spikes, which is the way vervain do their flowering. They begin with a little purple ring of flowers at the bottom of the spike about the first of July, and the flowers keep on blooming all summer, the ring creeping up higher and higher until school starts about the first of September, and pretty soon the flowers get clear to the top; then kinda like blue rings slipping off the ends of green fingers, they are all gone.

Well, in a jiffy, there we all were, standing around in a sort of half circle, looking over each other’s shoulders and between each other’s heads, right in front of Old Man Paddler’s dead wife’s tall tombstone. Her name had been Sarah Paddler, and she had died a long time ago. There were a couple of other tombstones there too, for the old man’s two boys who had died about the same time many years ago, and that old kind old man, whom the Sugar Creek Gang loved so well, had maybe been using all the love which he had had left over, when his own boys died, and, instead of wasting it on a dog or a lot of other things, he was pouring it out on us live boys instead.

Carved or chiselled on the tombstone was the figure of a hand with the forefinger pointing up toward the sky, and right below the hand were the words:

“There is Rest in Heaven.”

Standing on a little ledge, and fastened onto the tombstone with what is called scotch tape, was another envelope like the one we had just found and had read down at the Black Widow Stump, and on it it said,

U R G E N T
To the Sugar Creek Gang
(Personal. Open at once.)

Well, this time Big Jim took the envelope, and handed it to Little Jim who read it in his squeaky voice to all of us, and this is what it said in rhyme:

“The Sugar Creek Gang is on the right track
Now turn right around and hurry right back—
Go straight to the old hollow sycamore tree,
And there if you look, you will see what you see.”

This time it didn't say it was signed by “Guess Who,” but the poetry sounded like Poetry's poetry, and I looked at him and he was busy studying the ground around there to see if he could find any shoe tracks.

“Last one to the sycamore tree is a cow's tail,” Circus said, and started to make a dive for the cemetery fence just as Dragonfly got a queer look on his face, like he was going to sneeze but wasn't quite sure whether he was or not. Dragonfly looked toward the sun, which hurt his eyes a little, and that maybe made tears, which, with his face raised like that, tickled his nose on the *inside* and he let out one of his favorite sneezes, which was half blocked like a football kick, but went off to one side. Then he sneezed again three times, just as fast as if he couldn't help it, and said, “I'm allergic to something in this old graveyard. I'm allergic to ghosts.”

Right away we were all dashing toward the barbed-wire fence, and all of us got through without tearing our clothes and went zippety-zip-zip dash,

swerve, swish-swish-swish, toward the spring again, and down the path that led along the top of the hill toward Sugar Creek Bridge, and then across the old north road, and up a steep bank and down the path again toward the old sycamore tree and the swamp, and also toward the entrance to the cave which is a long cave, as you know, and the other end comes out in the basement of Old Man Paddler's log cabin back up in the hills.

"I'm thirsty," Poetry puffed beside me.

"So am I," I said, and right that second I remembered that when I'd gone to the spring in the first place, more than maybe an hour ago, I'd taken a water pail from our milk house and was supposed to bring back a pail of sparkling cool water, when I came home. "There isn't any hurry," Pop had told me, "but when you do come back be *sure* to bring a pail of water."

"I will," I had said to him, and now as we whizzed past the spring, I remembered that the water pail was on a flat stone down at the bottom of the hill at the spring.

"Who do you suppose is writing all these notes?" I said to Poetry, forgetting the water again.

"Yeah, who do you suppose?" Poetry said to me from behind me, he being so fat he couldn't keep up. "I know something I won't tell," he said to me, and when I said, "What?" he said, "Two little 'niggers' in a peanut shell."

"Don't call 'em niggers!" a voice behind us said, and it was Little Jim's voice.

"Why not?" Dragonfly wanted to know.

Say, Little Jim's voice which most of the time was very mild and kind, spoke up like it was angry and said, "'Cause negroes are real people, and 'cause—"

Right that second Little Jim's words got mixed up with a grunt which came out of his throat at the same time, and sounded so queer I turned

around to see what happened, 'cause I knew something had, and my eyes lit on him just in time to see him turn a lopsided flipflop on the ground. He had stumbled over a root with his bare right big toe, or else caught his bare right big toe in his overall leg and stumbled and fell sprawling.

I stopped quick, got bumped into by Poetry, who was behind me, but didn't fall down myself, whirled around and went back to help Little Jim get up.

Circus and Big Jim were far ahead of us. "Did you get hurt?" Little Tom Till asked, and Little Jim sat up rubbing his elbow and grinning and said, "You shouldn't call em niggers, 'cause they're human beings and God made 'em. My mother and dad have adopted a little black boy in Africa for a whole year. You can adopt one for only \$52.00 a year."

Say, that little guy had the most innocent lamb-like look on his face you ever saw. He was always saying things like that, and not a one of us thought he was too religious or anything. In fact, everyone of us had already become Christians ourselves, only most of us weren't quite as brave as Little Jim was, just talking right out about what we thought, without caring what anybody said, most of us thinking a lot more than we said. Poetry especially was bashful, especially in his Sunday school class, on account of his voice was changing and was more like a duck's with a bad cold, than a boy's, and was half man's and half boy's voice anyway.

"Come on! you guys!" Dragonfly yelled back to us from up ahead, and we all swished on.

It was quite a long run to the sycamore tree, but we got there quick, and found Circus and Big Jim looking inside the big long opening in its side for the letter or whatever it was we were supposed to find. In a jiffy Circus had it out and was waving it around in the air for us to see, and when we gathered around, we saw that it was an envelope with our names on it, only it was an actual honest-to-goodness letter with a postmark on it which, when I got close enough to see, I saw was Pass Lake, Minnesota.

Say, something in my heart went flippety-flop, and I just knew who the letter was from. For some reason I knew, *knew* what was going to be inside.

It was going to be a letter from the same great big fat man on whose property on Pass Lake we'd had our camp last summer, and he was inviting us to come up again for a week or two or maybe more.

Say, it certainly didn't take us long to find out that I was right, which I knew I was.

"It's from Santa Claus!" Dragonfly said, Santa Claus being the name we'd given to the man whom we'd all liked so well on our camping trip and whose wife had made such good blackberry pies.

Hurrah! Hurrah! Hurrah! We all read the letter, and felt so wonderful inside we wanted to yell and scream.

There was one paragraph in the letter that bothered us, though, and it was, "Be sure, of course, to get your parents' consent, all of you, and be sure to bring along your fishing tackle. Fishing is good. Little Snow-in-the-face will be eager to see you all. He has been very sick this past week, and has been taken to the government hospital. Be sure to pray for him. His big brother, Eagle Eye, has a real Sunday school going here, but his mother and father are not yet believers on the Lord Jesus Christ, and that makes it hard for him. But Snow-in-the-face is a very brave little Christian."

Right that second, we heard footsteps coming in our direction, and looking up I saw a dark brown smiling face, a row of shining white teeth with one all-gold tooth right in front, and I knew it was Barry Boyland, Old Man Paddler's nephew, who had taken us to Pass Lake last year.

"Hi, gang!" he called to us, and we called back to him, "Hello, Barry." And we all swarmed around him to tell him about the letter and to ask questions, all of us knowing that he was the one who had written the notes for us, just to make the last letter more mysterious and more of a surprise.

Well, it was time to go home, and try to convince our parents that we all needed a vacation very badly. For some reason I wasn't sure my folks would say I could go.

3

HOW'LL we do it?" I asked Poetry, as he and Dragonfly and I stopped at our gate to let Poetry and Dragonfly go on home, and to let me go on in.

"How'll we do *what*?" Dragonfly wanted to know, and right away sneezed at something or other, probably at some of the flowers in Mom's little flower bed around our mail box.

Dragonfly reached for and pulled out of his hip pocket his pop's big red bandana handkerchief and grabbed his nose just in time to stop most of the next three sneezes, which came in one-two-three style as fast as a boy pounding a nail with a hammer.

"How'll we convince our parents that we need a vacation?" Poetry said, and Dragonfly piped up and said, "People take vacations when they're worn out from too much work."

"Overworking?" I said, and Dragonfly sneezed again, and looked down at Mom's very pretty happy-looking different-colored gladiolus in the half-moon flower bed around the mail box.

"If you don't quit planting gladioluses around here, I can't come over and play here anymore."

"Or work, either," Poetry said, and I said, "Well, you guys better beat it, I've got to overwork a little." I opened our gate, squeezed through it and started on the run for our tool shed where I found a nice clean hoe which I'd cleaned myself the last time I'd used it, and in a few jiffies I was out in our garden hoeing potatoes as hard as I could, getting hotter and hotter and sweating like everything. Sweat was running off my face and I could feel it on my back, too. With a little wind blowing across from the woods and Sugar Creek I felt fine even in the hot sun. I certainly wasn't getting tired as

fast as I thought I would on account of when a boy sweats at hard work and the wind blows a little, he feels better than when he just kinda lazies around and tries to keep cool.

I wished Pop, who had gone somewhere for something, would hurry home and see me working hard. It was almost fun hoeing the potatoes, though it was kinda hard not to stop at the end of each row and pick and eat a few luscious blackberries which grew there. In fact, I did stop a few times, which is maybe why I got to the end of each row quicker.

Once I got thirsty, and went into the house for a drink of water, and Mom called out to the kitchen from the front room and said, “That you, Theodore?” which is Pop’s first name.

“Nope, it’s just me,” I said to Mom.

“Come on in a minute, Bill. Somebody wants to see you.”

“Who?” I said, wondering who it was and hoping it wasn’t anybody I didn’t know.

I peeked around the corner of the kitchen door and saw our lady Sunday school teacher. All of a sudden I felt good, although kinda bashful, on account of I was in my overalls and was probably very dusty and sweaty and maybe had my hair mussed up.

We said a few bashful words to each other, and she said, “I brought you that book of Indian stories,” and right away I was thinking of little “Snow-in-the-face” up North and wishing I could go up and see him again.

I thanked her for the book, and said, “Well—thanks, that’s swell—I mean, Thank you so very much,” which was what I thought Mom would want me to say in the way I said it.

“Don’t overwork,” she said to me with a smile in her voice, and I said “I will,” and was going out the kitchen door before I knew I’d said the wrong thing. She certainly was a good Sunday school teacher, and knew how to

make a boy like her, and also want to come back to Sunday school every Sunday.

Just as I was about to let the door shut behind me quietly like I do when we have company, I heard the news on the radio in the front room, and I knew that maybe Mom and my teacher had been listening to the radio when I came in, and had turned it low for a jiffy. One of the things I heard was about a little St. Paul, Minnesota girl named Marie Ostberg having been kidnapped and a reward being offered by the father... Then I heard the announcer mention something that I thought was a wonderful idea and it was: “Duluth—the hayfever colony—will have thousands of new visitors this year, because the heavy rains throughout the nation have made it the worst for pollen in many years. Thousands will be going north...”

That would give us two reasons why some of the gang ought to get to go—overwork and hayfever. Dragonfly had the hayfever, and if I worked awful hard, I might overwork, although it’d be easier to have hayfever if I could only get it.

Right that second, while I was picking up the hoe to go back to the potatoes again, I heard our car horn and Pop was at the gate, waiting for me to come and open it. Boy, was I ever glad I was hot and sweaty and that there were four or five long rows of potatoes already hoed which Pop could see himself.

“Hi,” I said to my reddish-brownish-mustached Pop. And he just lifted one of his big farmer hands and saluted me like I was an officer in the army and he only a private. I swung open the gate, and, seeing the gladiolus by the mail box, stopped and took three or four quick deep sniffs at them, just as Pop swung inside and stopped beside the big plum tree in the gravelled driveway.

Then I looked quick at the sun, to see if I could sneeze, and I actually did, three times in quick succession, just as Pop turned off the motor and heard me do it.

“I hope you aren’t going to catch cold,” Pop said, and looked at me suspiciously. “You boys go in swimming today?”

“The water was almost too hot,” I said. “I never felt better in my life, only——” Right that second, something in my nose tickled again and I sneezed and was glad of it. “Maybe I’m allergic to something down here....”

“Down *where?*” Pop said, and looked at me from under his heavy eyebrows, which I noticed weren’t up any more but were starting to drop a little in the middle, like he was wondering “What on earth?” and trying to figure me out, like I was a problem in arithmetic or something.

“I mean——” I started to answer him, and then decided maybe it was the wrong time to talk to Pop about what I wanted to talk to him about. So I said, “Well, I better get back to those potatoes. There are only two more rows.”

“*Back* to them?” Pop said, astonished. “You mean——?” He slid out of our long green car and looked toward the garden, and even from where we were, you could see that somebody had been hoeing the potatoes. “Well, what do you know about *that*? That’s wonderful! That’s unusual! That’s astonishing,” which I knew was some of Pop’s friendly sarcasm which he was always using on me, and I sort of liked it on account of Pop and I were good friends as well as he being my pop and I his red-haired, freckled-faced overworked boy, who didn’t have hayfever yet but was trying to get it.

Right that second I sneezed again, and Pop looked at me and said, “What’s that grin on your face for?” and I said, “Is there a grin on my face?”

“There certainly is,” he said, and I sighed and wished I could sneeze again, which for some reason I did, without even trying to, or looking at the sun, or smelling the gladiolus or anything, and I got a quick hope that maybe I was actually going to get hayfever.

Pop banged the car door shut, after taking out a paper bag which had something in it he’d probably bought somewhere in town. Then he said, “You’ve maybe been working too hard and been sweating, and with the wind blowing, you need a dry shirt. Better come in the house and help your mother and Charlotte Ann and me eat this ice cream,” which I did, our

Sunday school teacher helping also, she being the reason Pop had hurried to town to get the ice cream in the first place.

Then Mom told me to go gather the eggs, which I started to do, and ran ker-smack into something very interesting. I was up in our haymow looking for old Bentcomb's nest for her daily egg, which was always there if she laid one, although sometimes she missed a day.

"Well, what do you know?" I said to myself when I climbed up over the alfalfa to her corner. Old Bentcomb was still on the nest and her pretty bent comb was hanging down over her left eye. She was sitting there like she owned the whole haymow and who was I to be intruding?

"Hi, Old Bentcomb!" I said, "How're you this afternoon? Got your egg laid yet?"

She didn't budge, but just squatted down lower with her wings all spread out covering the whole nest.

"Where's your egg?" I said, and reached out my hand toward her, and "zip-zip-peck," quick as lightning her sharp bill pecked me on the hand and wrist. She wouldn't let me get near her without pecking at me, and when I tried to lift her off to see if she'd laid an egg today, she was mad as anything, and complained like she was being mistreated, and gave a saddish disgruntled string of cluck-cluck-clucks at me and at the whole world.

I let her stay and scooted down the ladder and ran ker-whizz to the house, stormed into our back door and said to Mom, "Hey, Mom, Old Bentcomb wants to 'set'! What'll we do—break her up or let her set?"

"For land's sakes," Mom said to me, "don't knock the world off its hinges!—*What! Old Bentcomb!*"

"Actually!" I said, "—up in the haymow!"

"We'll break her up," Mom said. "We can't have her hatching a nest of chickens up there."

“Couldn’t we make her a nest down here, out by the grape arbor? Couldn’t we put her in the new coop Pop and I made?”

“Better break her up,” Mom said, “she’s one of our best laying hens and if we set her, she’ll be busy all summer raising her family, and not an egg will we get.”

“But we break her up every year, and she never has a family of her own,” I said. “I think she’d look awfully proud and pretty strutting around the barnyard with a whole flock of little white chickens following her,”—which is one of the prettiest sights a boy ever sees on a farm—a mother hen with a whole flock of fuzzy-wuzzy little chickens behind and beside and in front of her, and running quick whenever she clucks for them to come and they all gather around her and eat the different things which she finds for them, such as small bugs, pieces of barnyard food, small grains of this or that and just plain stuff.

“Well, maybe you’re right,” Mom said, all of a sudden, “let’s set her. First, let’s get her nest ready and select fifteen of the nicest leghorn eggs we can find and have them all ready for her; then you go get her and bring her down.”

“She won’t want to leave her nice warm nest up in the haymow,” I said to Mom, looking up at her kinda pretty, warmish summer face under its blue sunbonnet.

“No, she won’t,” Mom said back to me, “But she’ll do it if we work it right. Hens are very particular about moving from one nest to another. We’ll maybe have to shut her up in the coop.”

Well, it was one of the most interesting things I liked to do around the farm. First, we took a nice brand new chicken coop which was just about as high as halfway between my knees and my belt, then we scooped a foot-in-diameter roundish hole in the ground close to our grape arbor, making the hole about only a few inches deep. We lined it with nice clean straw and then selected fifteen of the prettiest, cleanest white eggs we could find which had been laid that very day by the different leghorn other hens on our farm, and which would probably be what were called “fertile eggs” and

would hatch. Then I ran lickety-sizzle as fast as I could to our barn, scooted up the ladder into our haymow, and in spite of Old Bentcomb's being very angry and not wanting to leave her nest, I got her under one arm and brought her down the ladder.

In less than a jiffy or two, I was with her up to where Mom and I were going to coop her up in the coop. I stooped down first and looked into the dark inside of the coop and there was the prettiest, nicest most beautiful fifteen eggs you ever saw all side by each. The coop had a roof on it but no floor, the floor being the ground with the straw nest in it. I pushed Bentcomb very gently and in a friendly way up to the hole in the front of the coop, and let her look in at the nest full of eggs. She had been clucking like everything and whining and complaining in a saddish sort of voice which meant she wanted to be a mother of a whole flock of little chickens, but say! She was mad at me and didn't want to go in. She kept turning away from the hole in the coop not even looking at the nice new nest. So I said to her, "O.K., Old Bentcomb, I'll take you out and show you what will happen to you if you *don't* sit on those eggs."

I took her in my two hands, holding her tight so she wouldn't squirm loose and get away, and walked with her to our chicken house and around behind it to where there was a peach tree under which we had a pen with chickenyard wire all around and on top. Inside were about nine or a dozen of our best laying hens who had wanted to set, but whom we decided to "break up" instead of letting them have their stubborn hen-ways and "set." There they were, all shut up by themselves. Some of them were walking around with their wings all spread out, and clucking like they wanted a bunch of little chickens to come and crawl under them, and they were cluck-cluck-clucking in a saddish whining tone of voice. Over in one corner was a white egg which meant that one of the hens had already given up wanting to "set" and was behaving herself again like a good laying hen. And I thought that as soon as we could decide which one of the hens it was, we'd take her out and let her have her liberty again.

"See there," I said to Bentcomb, "look at those lonesome old hens! They're clucking around just like you've been doing. Every one of them wanted a family of her own, and not one of them is going to get it! If you

don't be good, and go in that coop like we want you to, we'll have to shut you up in here and leave you for two whole weeks, which we do to all hens who want to 'set' and we won't let 'em."

Say, Bentcomb wasn't interested at all. She absolutely refused to look, so I took her back again to the coop. "I'm going to give you one more chance," I said. "I want you to go in there carefully, not breaking any of those eggs, and behave yourself."

Once more I got down on my knees, holding her carefully like she was a very good friend, which she was, and so she could look in and see for herself what we wanted her to do.

Well sir, this time she must have decided to be good, 'cause all of a sudden, she quit struggling and looked in like she'd made up her mind it might be a good place for her to live for awhile. Without me doing any pushing, or anything, she very slowly started to creep inside the opening in the coop, toward the eggs. The next thing I knew she was on the nest, turning around and scooting herself down and spreading her wings out and settling down and covering every one of those fifteen eggs with her wings.

I turned and yelled, "MOM! She's gone in! She's going to set!"

"Put the board over the hole for a while," Mom said, "so she can't get out. Let her stay until she feels at home, and then she'll go back every time we let her out for exercise and water and food."

I put the rectangular shaped board over the door of Bentcomb's house, and propped it shut with a brick, so she couldn't get out.

And so we "set" my favorite hen, Old Bentcomb. In just three weeks there'd be a whole nestful of cheeping chicks and a very proud mamma hen. I sat down for a minute on the roof of her house to rest. I was almost overworked, I started to think, when Pop yelled, "Hey, Bill! Come on out! We've got to get the rest of the chores done!" So I started to the barn to help him do them, still thinking about the camping trip we'd all been invited to take, and wondering if I could get to go.

“Don’t you feel well?” Pop asked me when I was moving slowly around in the barn doing different things.

“Kinda worn out,” I said, and the dust which I’d been stirring up with a pitchfork over our corn elevator made me sneeze twice. “Maybe I’ve got hayfever,” I said.

“That’s that straw dust you’re stirring up there,” Pop answered.

“*Stirring up?*” I asked, and knew Pop was right. You just couldn’t fool Pop, I thought.

He stopped what he had been doing which was something or other way up at the other end of the barn, and called to me, “Next week, we’ll take you to the doctor and have him give you a test to see what makes you sneeze so much.”

“Some people sneeze a lot because of the rainy weather making so many different kinds of flowers and weeds grow so much and making so much pollen, maybe,” I yelled back in a tired voice.

Pop ignored my educational remark, and sent me up in the haymow to throw down some alfalfa for our Brindle cow. While I was up there, I stirred up the dust in the hay and sneezed three or four times real loud.

Just then Pop called up to me and said, “What’s the matter, Bill? Are you hurt?”—which made me feel foolish.

The sun was shining in through a crack in the barn and I peeped out like I nearly always do when I’m up there and looked around at the different things such as three rows of newly hoed potatoes in the garden. I could hardly believe my eyes, when I noticed that there were only *three* rows I’d hoed. It had seemed like seven.

Then my heart almost jumped into my mouth when I heard voices downstairs and one of them was Barry Boyland’s laughing voice. He and Pop were talking, and saying they were glad to see each other. I stopped in my tracks, and listened for all I was worth, and this is what I heard, “Well,

Barry, we *have* to do something for him—he's getting the hayfever so badly. Maybe the North would be good for him."

And then Barry laughed the queerest sounding laugh I'd heard in a long time and said, "Sure, I understand. It's the same story wherever I go—the boys of the Sugar Creek Gang are all sneezing pretty bad, all except Dragonfly, who is better this year than last—but his parents said he could go, too." Then Pop and Barry laughed long and loud at each other like it was funny or something. But I didn't care at all. I was so tickled inside.

Right away a terrible scream of happiness jumped up into my throat, and if I hadn't stopped it, I'd have yelled even worse than I do when I'm yelling for our baseball team.... Oh boy, oh boy—another trip up North this summer, with all the gang going along!

4

As I've already told you, when we were going to get to go North, we didn't have any idea we'd run into such an exciting and dangerous mystery, but when a gang of boys get together on a camping trip in the wild North, something is pretty nearly always bound to happen, which it did.

On the way we went through a city which advertised itself as the Capital of the Paul Bunyan Playground—Paul Bunyan being what is called a mythical lumberman of the North, and was supposed to have been terribly big like a giant in the story of Jack and the Beanstalk, which is a fairy story every boy ought to know—only instead of Paul Bunyan being a *bad* giant, he was a good one, and was always doing kind things for people.

We stopped to get some gas for Barry Boyland's station wagon—which is what we were all riding in—right across from a tourist camp called "Green Gables," and Little Jim gasped and said, "LOOK! Who and what is that?"

I looked out at what Little Jim was looking at, and saw what he saw, and it was a great statue of a man with a beard and mustache, standing with one hand upraised and the other on a back of a statue of a great big extra big blue cow which had horns. Poetry spoke up and said, "That's Paul and Babe."

"Paul and Babe *Who*?" Dragonfly wanted to know, and Poetry, who, as I've told you before, had a lot of books in his library, all of a sudden reached down into a briefcase he had with him and pulled out a book and said, "That's Paul Bunyan and his big blue ox, whose name is Babe. It was the blue ox whose footprints were so large that when it walked around they sank deep into the ground, and everywhere it went it left big holes. Then when it rained, the rain water filled up the holes and that made all the eleven thousand great big blue-watered lakes which live in Minnesota."

Little Jim, who likes fairy stories and legends, grinned and said, “What made the water *blue*, then? How come?” You see, nearly all the water in nearly all the great big hundreds of lakes we’d already seen on our trip was as blue as the blue on the hair ribbon Circus’ sister wore to school at Sugar Creek.

“What made the lakes blue?” asked Poetry with a question mark in his voice. He puckered his fat forehead, and said, “Blue—oh *that!*” He thumbed his way through the Paul Bunyan book quick, to see if there was anything in the book to explain it, but there wasn’t. So he said, “Old Babe, the ox, was blue, you know. One day when he was out swimming in the headwaters of the Mississippi, the blue began to come off, and pretty soon the Mississippi, which flows through a lot of lakes up here, was all blue. The water flowed all around from lake to lake and pretty soon the lakes’ waters were all blue, too!”

Well, it made as good an untrue story as any of the rest of the exaggerated ones in the Paul Bunyan book so we added it to the list and decided to tell it to our folks when we got back to Sugar Creek.

Pretty soon we drove on, right straight down through the pretty little modern-looking city, where there were lots of people walking the streets in vacation clothes.

Pretty soon we passed a Tourist Information place, on the right side of the road where there was a very tall cement water tower, that was shaped exactly like my pop’s big long six-battery flashlight back home, being a lot larger at the top. Little Jim squinted his pretty blue eyes up at it like he was thinking about something. Then we went on, and Poetry read to us different crazy things the mythical Paul Bunyan was supposed to have done, such as he had been such a big baby when he was born that it took six large storks to carry him to his parents; and Paul’s pet mosquitoes dug the wells up here where we were; his soup bowl was so large it was like a lake and the cook had to use a boat to get across it; also his pancake griddle was so large that they greased it by tying greasy griddlecakes on the bottoms of some men’s shoes and they skated around over its surface to grease it for Paul—things like that.

Little Jim surprised us all of a sudden by saying, “Anybody want to hear how all the people decided to move up into this country and stay here?—How Paul Bunyan and I working together got them to come, when nobody wanted to?”

“How?” Dragonfly wanted to know. “What do you mean YOU and Paul Bunyan worked it? Paul used to live here long before you were born. You never even saw him!”

“Oh I didn’t, didn’t I?” Little Jim asked and had a very mischievous grin on his innocent face. “Want to hear the story?”

“Sure,” Poetry and I said, and Dragonfly said, “No.”

Little Jim said, “All right, I won’t—anyway, it’s too important a story to tell to such a small unappreciative audience.” He sighed like he was sleepy and curled up with his head on my lap and sighed again and almost before I knew it he was actually asleep.

It felt good having Little Jim lying with his head in my lap, he being my almost best friend except Poetry, and also being a really wonderful little guy and was the best Christian in the whole Sugar Creek Gang. He was always thinking and saying important things about the Bible and heaven, and the One who had made the world, and also about His Son who had come here to this pretty world once and died on a cross which was made out of a tree, just to save anybody who would repent of his sins and believe on Him.

I looked down at that pretty curly head, and thought of Sugar Creek and my parents and little Charlotte Ann, and was lonesome for a minute. Then pretty soon I was sleepy myself and the flying tires of the station wagon sort of sang *me* to sleep too. Once I half woke up on account of Little Jim wiggled in my lap and I heard him mumbling something. I was too sleepy to listen, but it sorta sounded like he maybe thought he was at home getting ready to crawl into bed and go to sleep. I kinda bent my ear down a little and listened close to his perspiring face and say! I heard some of the prettiest words you ever heard in your life and they were, “Now I lay me down to sleep, I pray the Lord my soul to keep; if I should die before I wake, I pray the Lord my soul to take....” Little Jim was kinda mumbling

the words. I'd heard the poem before, in fact my folks had taught it to me, and when I was littler I'd said it at night myself. But Little Jim said something else I couldn't quite make out, but it sounded like this: "Please also—bless—Little Snow-in-the-face, and help him to get well..." Then I felt Little Jim's shoulder relax against my stomach and I knew he was sound asleep. In another jiffy I was asleep myself.

When I woke up we were still flying along with Barry at the wheel, and most of us sitting in lying-down positions, getting a swell afternoon nap. It was wonderful to ride along that fast, and also wonderful to see all the things we saw, as the road wound itself around and around like the winding barefoot-boy paths through the Sugar Creek woods along Sugar Creek itself. At the town of Pass Lake, most of us got out, stretched ourselves and bought postcards at a drug store and sent them to our folks. I sent a card that showed some men climbing a tree, and some great big fish were at the bottom looking up like hungry bears look up at boys.

I said to my folks, "Pretty soon we'll be making camp," which we did about a quarter of a mile from the place we'd been the year before on Santa's lake front property—Santa, as you know, being the great big laughing fat man who likes boys almost as much as Old Man Paddler does.

"Where's *Mrs.* Santa?" Poetry asked that kind person, maybe remembering the blackberry pie she'd given us, and maybe missing her very friendly and extra special giggle, which we'd all liked to hear so well. I had looked forward to seeing her laugh with her eyes as well as hearing her laugh with her bird-like voice.

Santa, who was sitting in his big white boat which was beached near where we were making camp, and was helping Tom Till get his fishing pole and line ready for a fishing trip in the morning, said to Poetry, "She's gone to California, but will be back early next week, before you boys have to go back to Sugar Creek."

Well, it was almost time for the sun to go down, and we would have to get busy pitching our tents. Barry called to us from the station wagon which was parked close by, "Hey, Gang! Let's get the tents up.... Hey, you, BILL! POETRY! TOM!"

We all beat it and pretty soon were working like boy scouts, doing what is called “making camp.” Barry’d picked a site not far from the lake, and also not too far from a wood pile, so a gang of boys who were lazy only when there was work to do, wouldn’t have to carry wood too far. Also he picked a place where there wouldn’t be too much shade so it wouldn’t be too damp, and yet there would be sunshine every day if there was any.

“Why don’t we put the tents under this big tree right here?” Circus asked, and Barry said, looking up at the tree, “See that great big half dead limb there?”

Dragonfly looked up and saw it, and said, “Sure, what of it?” and Little Jim spoke up and said, “The wind might blow some night,” and then turned and ran to where Big Jim was, about fifty feet away and who, with his jack-knife, was cutting green sticks of different sizes to help us make what Barry called an outdoor kitchen, which he said was going to be like the kind the Chippewa Indians used to use.

All of us were either giving or obeying orders, and in a few jiffies our tents were up and the outdoor kitchen was nearly finished.

“O.K., you guys—you and Poetry,” Barry ordered Poetry and me, “roll up a couple of those big round rocks over there, get a couple of forked sticks, and push them right into the fire.” We already had a roaring fire going in a place where it was safe to have one. No boy or anybody ought to start a fire in any forest or woods any time unless it is in a place where there is supposed to be one, and where it can’t spread, or a whole forest might get burned up.

“What on earth?” I thought, as Poetry and I grunted a round rock apiece up as close to the hot fire as we could, and then pushed them the rest of the way with forked sticks so we wouldn’t get burned, ourselves.

“Wait and see,” Barry said, and we did, but kept wondering, “Why on earth?” We got two other rocks also, while the rest of the gang helped put up the tents and made things ready for our first night’s sleep. I had a tingling feeling all inside of me, and just knew we were going to have the most wonderful time of our lives.

It didn't take us long to get supper over, which we cooked ourselves on a little two-burner pressure gas stove which Barry had brought along, he not wanting us to take time to cook in real Indian style, which we would most of the time.

"Ouch!" different ones of us said to each other and all of a sudden started slapping around at mosquitoes.

"Here—rub this on," Barry said, "and be careful not to get any too near your eyes and lips." He handed us a couple of bottles of mosquito lotion and we smeared our bare hands and ankles and necks and ears and faces with the sickenishly-sweetish-smelling stuff, and right away it was just like there wasn't a mosquito in the world.

Santa came over and we all sat around the camp fire, with the pretty sparks and flames playing above the beds of coal and the four large roundish rocks in the middle of it.

After we'd all listened to Barry tell us an honest-to-goodness Bible story about something that had happened on Galilee Lake once, we all took turns telling made-up stories. It was Little Jim who suggested we all make up Paul Bunyan stories and since it was a good idea, we decided to try to see who could make up the best one, and so we started. First, though, Barry told us the thrilling and very interesting Bible story, which maybe I ought to tell you here myself, 'cause it was one of the best stories a real red-blooded gang of boys ever heard.

All of us were in a sort of half circle around the camp fire, on blankets and also on each other, some of us leaning up against each other, like right that minute I was against Poetry.... "Get over," Poetry said to me. "Don't crowd so close."

"I'm trying to get warm," I said. "It's cold. I'm using you for a windbreak."

And Circus said to Poetry—"You're a windbreak when it's cold, and when it's hot we lie behind you in the shade,"—Poetry, as you know, being fat as a small cow. Most of us giggled, except Poetry.

“It happened like this,” Barry began,—and I noticed Little Jim reach into his vest pocket, and pull out his New Testament to look up the place where Barry was getting the story from. I did the same, and so did most of the gang, except Tom Till who had forgotten to bring his. I looked at him and he swallowed like he was embarrassed, so I reached out mine to him and he sort of looked on, although I knew he couldn’t see very well, and wasn’t very good at reading the Bible anyway. Besides it was more interesting to watch Barry’s brown face and his one all-gold front tooth sparkling in the firelight when he talked.

It was one of my very favorite Bible stories and was about some fishermen who lived near a great big blue-watered lake that was thirteen miles long and seven miles wide and had thousands of fish in it. Two brothers, named Peter and Andrew, were fishing, not with poles but with nets, and two other brothers whose names were James and John, whose Pop’s name was Zebedee and whose Mom’s name was Salome, were using another boat. I was feeling sorry for the double brothers ’cause they hadn’t caught any fish and I was wondering what their Moms would say when they got home, when Barry started in to telling about a big crowd of people coming along listening to Someone telling wonderful stories and also telling them about the Father in Heaven and how to live right and things like that; and the crowd got so close to the Speaker that He might have been crowded into the water.

He turned and asked Peter to let Him borrow his boat, so He could get into it and push out from shore a little, and then He could talk to the crowd and not get trampled on and also the crowd’d be able to see Him. It was a bright idea, I thought, and wished I had been there, ’cause if it was wonderful to hear our minister at Sugar Creek tell about Him in his very interesting sermons, it would have been even wonderfuller to have been beside that pretty blue-watered lake that day and listened to the Saviour right while He was talking....

Pretty soon, the Speaker’s sermon was over, Barry said, and then He, just as if He wanted to pay Peter for being so courteous as to let Him make a pulpit out of his boat, told Peter to shove the boat into the deep water and let down the nets for some fish.... Say, Peter didn’t want to do it, ’cause he

had been fishing around there all night, and hadn't caught anything, and he might have wondered, "Why do it again and make a fool of myself?"

"But," said Barry,—and I could see his all-gold tooth shining as he talked, and even though he was smiling, his face was very sober—"it is better to obey the Lord, boys, even if it does seem foolish to the world for you to do it, than it is to *disobey* Him. Besides, He has a right to give us orders, since He is the Son of God...."

He kept on talking, but for a minute, I looked at Circus, who I noticed had his fists doubled up, and was lying on his stomach and his elbows, looking up and across the fire at Barry. Also he had his chin resting on his doubled-up fists and the muscles of his jaw were working and I knew he was maybe imagining himself to be Peter and his thoughts were right out in that pretty lake, and he was seeing the whole thing with his mind's eye like I was....

When my thoughts got back to Barry again, he was farther along in the story to where the net was suddenly jammed full of great big bouncing, swishing, lunging, splashing fish, and Peter and Andrew had to have help to pull the net in. Also right that second, the big strong net began to break in places and some of the fish were getting away, so Peter let out a yell for James and John to make a dive for their boat—in fact, to bring their boat with them which they did quick, and both of the boats were so jammed full of fish that both of them started to sink. That scared Peter, and also all of a sudden Peter realized that the Man he'd been listening to was more than a man, but was also the Lord. He all of another sudden realized what a terrible sinner he was, and he forgot all about the bouncing, swishing, lunging, splashing fish and dropped down on his knees and cried out to the Lord, "Go away, Lord, leave me. I'm a sinful man!"—on account of he was so ashamed of himself for being a sinful man, he didn't think he was good enough to be anywhere near the Lord....

But say, Jesus had done all this on purpose to get Peter to believe in Him, and He told him not to be afraid any longer, but said, "Fear not; henceforth thou shalt catch men..."

When Barry said that, Circus' bright eyes lit up and he interrupted the story to say, "What'd he mean by that?" Before Barry could answer, Little Tim Till surprised us all by cutting in and saying across the crackling fire to Circus, "He meant, 'Don't be scared; from now on you'll be what our Sugar Creek minister calls a *soul winner*.'"

Well, it was a wonderful true story, and for some reason I had the happiest feeling all inside of me. I not only wished all of a quick sudden that I had been there and had maybe been Peter or Andrew or one of Mother Salome's two boys, but I felt also that maybe the most important thing in the world was to be a soul winner, or a fisher of men...

Well, the story was done and the sky above the lake toward where the sun had gone down, reminded me of the reddish, purplish and also yellowish spread-out feathers of a terribly big fantail pigeon.

I WAS sitting there on a small log, looking at the extra beautiful sky, looking at it over the top of our camp fire, thinking about how the rays of the sun shooting up looked like a lady's many colored unfolded fan or the tail of a fantailed pigeon, when Barry said, "One of the Sporting Clubs up here is offering a prize for the best original Paul Bunyan story... Here's a chance for you boys to stretch your imaginations a little..."

Pretty soon we were all racking our brains to see if we could think of something about Paul Bunyan that nobody had ever thought of before, which Barry might decide was good enough to write about and send in to the contest... Different ones of us made up different things, such as: One time Paul Bunyan gave a wintertime party in a terribly big recreational center in Bemidji, and so many people answered his invitation and came that there wasn't any place to hang their fur coats and other heavy coats, so Paul went out and blew on his horn and hundreds of great big huge antlered deer came running in from all directions, and Paul stood them up all around the outer wall of the building, each one of them facing the center, and the fancy ladies hung their fur coats and other kinds of different colored coats on the antlers, using them for what is called "costumers." Those deer stood there patiently, without moving, with their kind eyes watching the skaters.

Everything was going fine, until somebody opened all the doors all around to let in some fresh air, and then all of a sudden, Old Babe, the blue ox came in and started lumbering around looking for Paul, and stamped his hoofs and snorted like a mad bull, and the people got scared and excited and the women started to screaming, and that scared the hundreds of deer, and they bolted for the doors in a terribly mad and wild scramble, and, there being doors all around that were open, they took all the coats with them...

That was Big Jim's story, and when he told it, I remembered that he always got very good grades in English in the Sugar Creek School.

Dragonfly told his story, and it was that Paul Bunyan got hay fever so bad and sneezed so hard and so many times in succession that it blew a whole forest over; Poetry said Paul Bunyan ate so many blackberry pies and got so fat that when he went in swimming in Leech Lake and splashed around a lot, so much water splashed *out* of the lake for hundreds of miles around that it made a thousand *new* lakes so that the ten thousand lakes that Minnesota had at first were changed to eleven thousand; Circus said the day Paul ate Poetry's blackberry pies he had to have toothpicks to pick the seeds out from between his teeth, so he cut down some Norway pines with his jack-knife which was seven feet long, and used them for toothpicks; Dragonfly looked at me and my red hair, with a mischievous grin in his dragonfly-like eyes, and told another story real quick which was: Paul's long hair was so red that when he was asleep one windy day, the Indians saw it blowing in the wind and thought it was a forest fire. They threw water all over him, and ever since then, all red-haired people have been all wet.

Well, that was supposed to be funny, and most everybody around the camp fire thought it was and laughed hard, but it wasn't funny, maybe. For a minute I was almost mad, but decided it would be a waste of good temper to spoil what the others thought funny; besides my pop says any boy who wants to get along with people can't afford to always be taking offense. I couldn't think of anything about Paul Bunyan that would help me get even with Dragonfly, so I let Little Jim tell his story, and we didn't have time for mine, on account of it was time to go to bed.

I watched Little Jim's small friendly face in the firelight and in the light of the afterglow of the sun which had already gone to bed, and he looked so innocent, that you couldn't tell whether he was thinking or not, but it was fun to listen to him, 'cause his mouse-like voice squeaked out the strangest story, which really sounded good, and it was: "Well, when Paul and I were up here in this pretty country of many lakes, we got awful lonesome and wished there were some people living here. We stayed down where Brainerd is now, and Paul would carry me around in his vest pocket and tell me stories, and complain about how lonesome he was..."

Well, it sounded like Little Jim was going to have a real good story, so I listened and sure enough it was. That little innocent-faced guy said that Paul Bunyan got so lonesome finally that he took his big long brown flashlight and some different colored cellophane and stood the flashlight, which was two hundred feet long, up on the ground, and built a wooden platform around it right at the place where the switch was, and every night Little Jim sat on that platform of the two-hundred-foot-tall flashlight and turned that light on and off and on and off; and Paul would stand beside the flashlight and slide different colored pieces of cellophane paper across the top of the flashlight, and the whole sky was all lit up in many different colors every night, changing just like the beautiful northern lights do—(and I thought that maybe the sky above the lake had made little Jim think about the different colors)—and pretty soon in a week or so, people from Iowa, Missouri, Tennessee, and all the southern states, began to come up North to see what they thought were beautiful northern lights, and they liked the country so well they decided to stay and build their homes, which they did, and so the town of Brainerd was founded, and then Paul left his flashlight standing and the people took the big batteries out and used it for a water tower, where it still stands in downtown Brainerd.

Well, it was a cute idea, and I wished I could think of something good, but couldn't, so we broke up our campfire circle, with Santa standing and yawning his fat self into a straightened up posture. He looked straight at Tom Till and said, "How about a spin on the lake, with my new outboard motor, Tom?"

I remembered that Santa and Mrs. Santa didn't have any children of their own, and that last year he had liked Tom so well, and had also been the one who had showed Tom how to become a Christian. I knew that Tom's pop was an infidel, and was hardly ever kind to him, and Tom was maybe hungry for some grown-up person to like him, so I felt happy inside that Tom was going to get a fast boat ride, although I wanted to go along worse than anything.

"You, too, Bill—and Poetry, if you like," Santa said—"if you can spare them awhile, Barry. I'll take the rest of the gang tomorrow. This new motor needs breaking in, you know."

Well, it was all right with Barry, and it certainly was all right with me, so away we four went toward the sandy shore to where Santa's big white boat was beached, each one of us taking our life preserver vests, and putting them on before getting into the boat... Boy oh boy, that lake looked wonderful, having as many colors as the sky itself, which meant that a lake got its color from the sky, I thought, and said to Poetry, "Looks like Old Babe, the Ox, must have changed his colors like a chameleon and taken a swim out here, while we were telling stories."

And Poetry surprised me by yelling, "SWELL, BILL, that's wonderful! Hey, you guys back there! Bill's got a good story!"

Well, it made me feel half proud of myself to have Poetry yell that to the gang like that, and I liked Poetry a lot for a minute, that being one of the reasons why I liked him anyway—he was always making a person feel like he was worth something.

It certainly felt fine to sit in the prow of Santa's big boat, with Tom Till and Poetry in the middle and Santa himself in the stern, and go roaring out across the lake. Boy oh boy, in the afterglow of the sunset, the lake was pretty, and without much wind was as smooth as Mom's mirror in our front room at home. I was wishing Pop and Mom were there, to see things, but wouldn't want them to stay on account of I wanted to have some real exciting adventures to tell them about when we got home...

Pretty soon, our boat cut a wide circle around the end of a neck of land, and we went roaring down the other side about fifty or maybe a hundred feet from shore. It was still a little light on the lake, but the pine trees on the shore looked darkish and it was getting dark fast. All the time I was wondering if we could run into any exciting adventures up here in the North when Poetry said, "Look Bill! right there's where our boat upset last year and tossed us out, and right there's where I hooked that big Northern Pike."

I remembered and yelled back to him and said so, and went on thinking—wishing we'd have some kinda scary excitement as well as a lot of fun camping.

I watched the widening waves that spread out behind us like a great V, and felt fine and happy, and for some reason I liked everybody. Also I was remembering the Bible story Barry had told, and how Peter was afraid to have the Lord anywhere near him, because he was a sinner, and I began to feel that God was real close to all of us and I wasn't a bit scared of Him 'cause I knew that He had washed all my sins away, which our Sugar Creek minister and Little Jim say is what He does to a boy or anybody who will really let Him—washing them away in His own blood.

Just then Poetry yelled to me, "Penny for your thoughts, Bill!" I started, and looked at him and said, "Look at that reddish sky, will you?" and Poetry looked and said, "Kinda pretty, isn't it?"

6

WE docked at Santa's dock, and went into his log cabin with him. It was cozy inside. First he lit two old-fashioned kerosene lamps, then 'cause it might get cold pretty soon, we helped him start a fire in his small wood stove in a corner; Tom pumped a pail of water from the pitcher pump inside the cabin. Santa even had an icebox with ice in it, and in another small room, twin beds; and back in a tiny room away back in the back, there was a bathtub and beside it a very old-fashioned trunk that for some reason made me think of Robinson Crusoe and buried treasure. I wished harder than ever that we would run into a mystery up here in the North.... I was all tingling inside, wanting one so bad. But, of course, I wouldn't want the kind that would half scare a boy half to death, like the ones that sometimes happened to the Sugar Creek Gang, but I wanted an ordinary mystery anyway.

Pretty soon it would be time to go back to camp and get to sleep. I was wondering how we could keep warm in our cold wall tents—which was the kind ours were—when there wouldn't be any fires inside and we didn't have any heaters. Of course I knew I'd be pretty warm myself, after I'd crawled into my sleeping bag, which is a waterproof bed made out of khaki drill. It had a soft kapoc filled mattress, and I would just crawl into it, zip up the zipper slide fastener on the side, and there I'd be, but it'd be cold to get undressed and before getting into my pajamas.

Santa showed us different things in his cottage, such as a large mounted fish on the wall which Mrs. Santa had caught, and also a great big bearskin rug which was on the floor and had a fierce bear's head with wide open red mouth on one end of it; also there was a snake skin on the wall, which a missionary in Africa had sent him.

Well, it was soon time to go home. Poetry looked at Santa's wood box and said all of a sudden, "You need a load of wood—better let Bill carry

one in for you.”

“Fine,” I said, “I’ll hold the flashlight for you.” I took a flashlight off the table, and started toward the door with Poetry right after me.

Outside, we looked back through the window at the pretty little cabin and at Santa and Tom standing by the fire warming themselves, and all of a sudden Poetry said, “I wish Tom had a pop like—I wish Santa was Tom’s daddy.”

I thought of old hook-nosed John Till at Sugar Creek and knew that maybe right that very minute he was probably standing at the bar in a beer joint sousing his fat stomach with beer, and that Tom’s mother was maybe not even going to have enough money to buy groceries for the family the rest of that week.

At the long wood rick, Poetry and I stopped and he said, “Sh! Turn off the light. I heard something.” I snapped off the flashlight, peered out into the dark and listened. “It’s a crazy loon,” I said, when one of those diving birds away out on the dark lake somewhere had let out a long-tailed quavering cry, which came echoing across to where we were. Also right that second another loon, closer to the shore, answered him.

And then my hair started to stand up on end, ’cause I heard another sound almost like that of a loon, but it wasn’t coming from that lake. It sounded like a little girl crying and came from over in the direction of the boathouse where Santa kept his boat in the winter and his tools and oars and things in the summer.

Then I heard the sound again, plain as day, a faint cry like a loon that somebody was trying to smother, and maybe had his fingers on its throat...

Poetry’s hand was tightening on my shoulder, and his face was close to my neck, and I could hear and feel him breathing. “Over *there*,” he whispered huskily, “close to the boathouse. *Down!*” he hissed, and drew me down beside him, both of us hiding behind the wood rick.

Before I ducked, though, I'd looked in the direction of the boathouse which was up against the edge of a steep hill, and I saw a tiny glow like somebody had drawn on a cigarette or cigar and it had made it glow in the dark.

I knew it couldn't be any of our camping party 'cause not a one of us smoked, not even Barry.

Then we heard the boathouse door creaking on its hinges and I knew I was beginning to be scared.

"It's a man smoking," Poetry hissed in my ear, but I didn't want to believe it. "Maybe it was a lightning bug," I said. There were several of them flashing their spooky little lamps on and off out near Santa's boat.

"Lightning bugs' lights are a yellowish green," Poetry said, "and that was a reddish glow."

I knew he was right but wished in spite of wanting a mystery that whatever it was, it wasn't some criminal. Then I heard what sounded like a stifled cry again and knew it *wasn't* any loon, but said to Poetry, "It's a loon's echo, maybe."

I had the flashlight in my hand and without thinking, but just doing what I wanted to, shot its long white beam right straight toward the boathouse, up against the hill. Before I could even think Poetry had reached out a hand and grabbed my arm and smothered the light against his fat side, but not before I saw what I saw, which was a dark shadow of something dart behind the boathouse.

"Don't scare whatever it is," Poetry said. "Give me time to think what to do," Poetry, as you know, being the one of our gang which wanted to be a detective and knew more about being one than any of the rest of us.

We were both ducked behind the wood rick again and our knees were on a pile of sawdust, which maybe had been left there when somebody had maybe cut the wood with a buzz-saw. Even with a scary mystery just around the corner, Poetry quoted something he had memorized, which was.

“If a wood-saw would saw wood,
How much wood would the wood-saw saw
If the wood-saw would saw wood?”

“I thought you wanted to think,” I said to him.

“I am,” he said. “I think best when I have what books call a ‘poetic muse.’ Did you notice what I noticed?” he asked me.

“What?” I said, and he said, “That the boathouse has had a new coat of paint since we were here, last year.”

“I saw a shadow move,” I answered him. I was trembling inside and listening toward the boathouse.

We kept on listening but didn’t hear a thing, so we decided to turn the flashlight on the boathouse again, which we did, and sure enough it had been painted, a nice pretty green color. It even looked like it had *just* been painted.

“Smell the paint?” Poetry said, and I did—for the first time.

That green boathouse had its door closed and looked as innocent as Little Jim’s face looks when it is, and there wasn’t a sound of any kind. A lonely loon let out a wavering wail from across the lake and another one answered him from close to the shore, not far from the dock where we had just left Santa’s boat, but there wasn’t another sound anywhere.

“What about the door creaking on its hinges?” I said.

“Just remember it, when we start to questioning the suspect later on,” Poetry said, and his voice was as calm as if he was actually a detective. But his hand was on my arm, and I could feel it trembling a little. We loaded up our arms with wood as quick as we could and started toward the cottage.

We were both trembling when we got inside, but we’d made up our minds to keep quiet so as not to scare Tom Till. Also if we were only

imagining things on account of wanting a mystery so bad, and if there really wasn't any, we didn't want to seem silly to anybody except ourselves, which wouldn't be so bad.

We unloaded our two armloads of wood into the big wood box in the corner beside the stove, and then looked around and saw on the table in the corner a copy of a Minneapolis newspaper, and on the very front page, a big headline which said, "FEAR OSTBERG KIDNAPPER HIDING IN CHIPPEWA FOREST."

I stared and stared at the heading and sidled quickly over to the table, and in the light of the flashlight, on account of the kerosene lamp not being bright enough, I read the whole story.

I was remembering the radio program I'd heard back in our house at Sugar Creek, about a little girl being kidnapped at St. Paul... Poetry sidled over to me and we read the newspaper together while Santa and Tom Till were opening the icebox and getting out some bottles of pop. Poetry's hand was gripping my arm so tight that it hurt, but I didn't say a word. I was concentrating on the news story of the little girl who had been taken from her home in St. Paul, and hadn't been found yet, and I was making up my mind that the kidnapper or whoever he was, was maybe right that minute right out there in Santa's boathouse, and the Ostberg girl was there, too. The father of the little golden haired girl had already paid the ransom money of \$25,000 but the kidnapper hadn't left the girl where he'd promised to.

IT was hard to keep still while we were drinking our pop from Santa's icebox; in fact, I couldn't, so I said, "You been doing some painting around here, Santa? I smell fresh paint outdoors."

Santa set his bottle of orange pop down on the table and swallowed, and said, "The boathouse? Yes, I gave it a new coat yesterday—I've been doing a little work inside, too—doing it up in green and white. I plan to use it for a den for my fishing tackle and guns, and a place to write, and when I have company, it'll do for a guest house—or a sleeping room, anyway—"

Say, right that second, Santa got a queer look on his face, straightened up and said, "What do you know? I just remembered I forgot to lock the boathouse door."

Tom Till spoke up and asked, "Do the Indians steal things up here when you leave the doors unlocked?" and Santa answered and said something everybody ought to know, which was: "There are *white* people up here who do. We have very little trouble with the Indians themselves. They like to be trusted, and if they think you've locked the door especially because of them, they resent it. Of course, there are Indians and Indians, as there are white men and white men. A man isn't a thief because he's an Indian or of any other race, but because he has a sinful nature, which all men do have. You know a man decides for himself whether he is going to steal or not. It doesn't matter what the color of his face is, if he has a black heart."

Santa stretched himself and started toward the door.

I was wondering about Little Snow-in-the-face, and when we'd get to see him, and said so, and Santa said, "He's still in the hospital. He'll be thrilled to death to see you boys. He's a great little boy."

Santa opened his cabin door to go out and lock the boathouse door.

I looked at Poetry, and he looked at me, and we stared at each other. "Let's all go," Santa said.

In a jiffy, we were all outside, following Santa, walking in and along beside the white path his flashlight made.

"Well, what do you know!" Santa said all of a sudden, stopping and holding the light on the door. "I must have locked it after all, and forgotten I did it."

At the door we stopped while he shone the light on the Yale padlock on the door, and sure enough it was locked.

Santa laughed and said, "Must be getting forgetful in my old age." He turned, shot the flashlight all around, focusing it on stumps, out between us and the dock, also on the cottage and the chimney, and on a hole in a hollow tree just above the boathouse, and would you believe it? There sitting in the hole was a rust-red blinking longish-eared screech owl like an olderish woman sitting on the front porch of her house.

Quick as a flash, the owl spread its wings and flew like a shadow out into the night.

Poetry and I looked toward each other and sighed, and knew we'd been fooled by our own imaginations, 'cause if there's anything a girl sounds like when she is half crying in a high-pitched voice around the Sugar Creek school, it is a screech owl, which makes a sort of moaning, wavering wail....

Well, that was that, and I felt very foolish, as all of us went back to Santa's dock, climbed into his boat, holding his flashlight and also a bright electric lantern which you are supposed to do when you are out on a lake in a boat, so you won't run into some other boat and some other boat won't run into you.

In a little while we were roaring out across the darkish water, around the neck of land and back toward camp.

Pretty soon, Poetry and Dragonfly and Circus and I were in our own tent, with a small candle for a light on a folding table in one corner. It was as warm as toast in the tent in spite of it being really chilly outside, like it is most every night in the Paul Bunyan country.

“What on earth is that water pail doing in the center of the tent?” I asked, ’cause it was right where I wanted to set my suitcase and open it.

“That’s our stove,” Circus said.

“Stove?... That’s a water pail!” Poetry exclaimed.

“That’s where I want my suitcase,” I said, and started to move it, but Circus yelled, “Don’t touch it. You’ll get burned. It’s a stove!”

In the flickering light his monkey face looked ridiculous, and I, knowing how mischievous he was, said, “You’re crazy,” and started to take hold of the handle of the pail, and did, and let go in a fierce hurry. The handle was hot, and there was a lot of heat coming from the outside of the pail and a whole lot coming from the inside. It was pretty dark in the tent so I carried the candle from the corner, and looked in, and—would you believe it?—Well, I wouldn’t have, if I hadn’t seen it, but there it was—one of the big round rocks Poetry and I had rolled into the fire a couple hours ago. It was still as hot as anything, and would maybe stay hot nearly all night.

Pretty soon, I had crawled into my sleeping bag, and with Poetry in his, right beside me, and Dragonfly and Circus on the other side of the tent in theirs, we were ready to try to stop talking and go to sleep. Circus snuffed out the candle, and we all were quiet as we could be for awhile, which wasn’t quiet. We could also hear the rest of the gang—which was Big Jim and Tom Till and Little Jim and also Barry Boyland—still talking over in their tent maybe fifty feet away on the other side of the camp fire.

In spite of having been scared by my own imagination, I was awful sleepy and in a few jiffies was so sleepy I knew that in a minute I’d be gone. I was so sleepy I knew I wouldn’t be able to say a very good good-night prayer to the Heavenly Father. It was better for a boy to do most of his praying when he is wider awake anyway, but I managed to say a few words

which I meant from the bottom of my heart, and they were that the little girl's parents wouldn't go crazy on account of their little girl being stolen. I also prayed for little Snow-in-the-face and maybe a few other things.

Our gang hardly ever prayed together, on account of boys being bashful about doing it, but each one of us nearly always prayed by himself. Once in a while, though, we did when it was something extra important, and we thought maybe God wanted us to ask Him about it.

It certainly was a wonderful feeling—lying there in my cozy sleeping bag, warm as toast, listening to mosquitos buzzing around my face but not getting bit even once on account of I had mosquito lotion on my face and even on my ears, all of us being very careful, like the directions on the bottle said, not to get any on our lips or too near our eyes. Besides, there weren't any mosquitos in the tent on account of the window in our tent had mosquito netting built into it and it was mosquito proof.

I certainly was glad I hadn't told anybody I thought anybody had been kidnapped and was maybe in Santa's boathouse. I didn't want to seem ridiculous to anybody except to Poetry and myself; for some reason, though, I wished I had been right, on account of, as my pop once said, anybody doesn't like to believe he is wrong, even when he is.

I drifted away into a half dream, and it seemed like I could hear the washing of the lake wavelets on the shore, and they were mixed up with Dragonfly's snoring. Also it seemed like somebody was near me with a saw and was sawing wood, and the pile of sawdust was getting higher and higher, and Poetry and I were standing ankle deep in it. Then, I took off my shoes to get the sawdust out of them, and they were filled with green and white paint. Then somebody started pounding and making a slapping noise beside me, and I woke up, and it was Dragonfly's twisting and turning in his sleep and slapping at his face and ears. So I said to him, "'Smatter?" He answered back to me in a whining whisper and said, "These crazy mosquitoes are driving me wild. They are the biggest mosquitoes in the world!"

"Didn't you put on any lotion?" I hissed back to him, and he said, "No, I'm allergic to it. It makes me sneeze!" Right that second he sneezed twice,

so I said, “You’re probably allergic to mosquitoes, too.”

That woke Poetry up and he groaned a couple times and then really woke up and said, “Talk about big mosquitoes. Did you ever hear the story about the two big mosquitoes who had a noisy argument?”

“It sounds like we are on the midway of a mosquito circus right now,” Dragonfly said.

“I mean it,” Poetry began, “—there was a real argument between two big mosquitoes who lived up here in the Chippewa Forest. One night two of them were flying around, looking for somebody to eat, and they found Dragonfly lying asleep out on the beach. So one of them said, ‘Let’s pick him up and fly him home and eat him *there*.’”

“‘Naw,’ the other one said, ‘let’s don’t. Let’s eat him right here, ’cause if we *do* take him home, the big ones will just take him away from us.’”

We made Dragonfly put on some lotion and pretty soon he was asleep again, but I was wide awake, thinking about the kidnapper. Right that second Poetry nudged me and said, “Bill—Sh!”

I rolled over close to his face, and he said, “I’ve got an idea.”

Right away I was wide awake, and he said, “Remember the time I had a hunch back at Sugar Creek, and you and I got up and went out in the night and the gang captured a robber, digging for buried treasure down by the old sycamore tree.”

“Well?” I said, and he said, “I’ve got that same kind of a hunch tonight. I still think that screech owl wasn’t what we heard. Why didn’t we open the boathouse and look in?”

I wondered that myself, now that he had mentioned it.

I heard Poetry’s zipper on his sleeping bag zip a long zip. All of a sudden my heart began to beat faster, and I knew he and I were going to get up and go down to that boathouse and investigate. There wouldn’t be any real

danger, but if there *was* any little girl in there, we could probably hear her, and we could wake up Santa, or Barry and the whole gang. And if there wasn't anything to our idea, then we still wouldn't seem ridiculous to anyone except ourselves.

8

I WAS glad there was a little wind blowing so that the waves of the lake were washing against the shore, and also that Dragonfly snored so we wouldn't be heard if we kept real quiet.

In a few jiffies, Poetry and I had our shoes on, and our trousers and sweaters, and had worked our way out through the tent opening in the front, and with our flashlights we were sneaking up along the beach toward Santa's cabin and his boathouse.

Suddenly I stopped. The whole idea seemed absolutely crazy to me. I said, "You don't think for a minute that any kidnapper would be dumb enough to hide out in a boathouse that wasn't any more than fifty yards from where somebody actually lived, do you?"

"Who said anything about any kidnapper hiding out?" Poetry said. "He's maybe a hundred miles away from here by now. But he could have left the Ostberg girl there, couldn't he?"

"Why?" I said, and he stopped and hissed in my ear, "Not so loud!" We'd been following a little footpath we knew about, from having been there the year before.

I was trembling inside, maybe being a little cold, and at the same time couldn't see any sense to Poetry's thinking maybe the kidnapper was in that boathouse with the Ostberg girl. It didn't make sense.

"You're scared!" Poetry accused me, and I said I wasn't, but only thought the idea was crazy.

"It *can't* be," Poetry said. "Listen—" Then he told me what he'd been thinking, and it was, "What if the kidnapper, who, as the paper said, is

supposed to be a lumberman, was looking for an empty cabin up here somewhere to hide out in, and suppose he drove off onto a side road, to dodge the police who were maybe looking for his car, and suppose he got off on the little half-obliterated road that leads to Santa's cabin which nobody hardly ever uses and suppose he found the boathouse with the door open, and then just suppose that he put the girl in there, gagged and tied up, like kidnappers do, and then suppose that while he was there, Santa with us boys with him came roaring up to the dock in his boat. Wouldn't the kidnapper be scared, and maybe lock the girl in, and beat it himself, and—"

Well, it made a little sense, so I hurried along behind Poetry, my heart beating faster because we were hurrying so fast. Pretty soon we were almost there, when Poetry stopped all of a sudden and said, "Sh!"

I shushed quick, 'cause I'd heard it as plain as day myself. There was the sound of a car motor running, somewhere. It sounded like it was at the top of the hill away up above the boathouse. We knew there was a sandy road up there, 'cause we'd been on it once ourselves.

"Somebody's stuck in the sand," Poetry said, and it sure sounded like it. The motor was whirring and whirring. I'd seen cars stuck in sand and snow before, and I could imagine the driver, whoever he was, doing what is called "rocking" the car, and starting and shifting from first gear to reverse and back and forth, and the wheels spinning, and still the car not getting out of the sand...

We were real close to the boathouse now. Poetry shoved the beam of his light toward the door, and we both let out an excited gasp. I couldn't believe my eyes, and yet I had to, 'cause the boathouse *door was wide open, and the hinge of the lock was hanging like somebody had forced it open with a crowbar or something.*

We flashed our lights around inside, and there wasn't anybody there, but a cot in the other end was mussed up like somebody had been lying down on it. A pile of shavings were on the floor and were also scattered around under a carpenter's work bench. On the wall above the work bench were a lot of tools such as screwdrivers, saws, planes, and other carpenter's tools. Santa had maybe been working there, making something during the day.

“Quick!” Poetry ordered. “Let’s go up the hill and get his license number.”

I wanted to tell Santa or Barry or somebody, and get a lot of noisy action around there, but I knew Poetry was right. We were maybe already too late, and we maybe couldn’t do anything helpful. We’d probably be shot if we were seen by the man, whoever he was. But if we could get the car license number, it might help the police to trail him, if he really was the kidnapper.

Up that hill we went, following that hardly-ever-used road. At the top of the hill, we turned right and zipped along the edge of Santa’s woods, where you could hardly see the road at all, but we knew it would come out at the sandy road a little later, which it did. We could see, even with our flashlights off, which they had to be, that it was a newish car, as we sneaked up behind it. It had its tail light on and only its parking lights, and the driver was “rocking” it, starting slowly, going forward a few feet, then backwards, then forward, but not getting anywhere.

Already I was close enough to see the license, but didn’t dare turn on my flashlight, or the guy would find out we were there. “Wait,” Poetry said, “I’ll sneak up behind that tree.” Right away he started to start. Then he hissed to me, “DOWN, BILL! QUICK!”

Down we ducked and didn’t dare make a sound, ’cause the motor had stopped and the guy was opening his car door and getting out. Right there in front of our eyes not more than fifty feet away, we saw him make a dive for the back left wheel, and heard him mumbling something that sounded like mad swear words, and for a second I was glad that Little Jim wasn’t there, ’cause it always hurts him terribly to hear anybody swear, on account of the One whose Name is used in such a terrible way when a person swears is Little Jim’s best Friend. I was glad he wasn’t there for another reason, too, and that was that when he hears somebody using filthy rotten words like that, he can’t stand it and sometimes calls right out and says, “STOP SWEARING!”

We certainly didn’t want anybody to call out to that guy in the automobile.

“What’s he doing?” I whispered in Poetry’s ear, and didn’t need to have asked, on account of I heard a hissing noise coming from that left back tire.

“The crazy goof!” I said to Poetry, “He’s letting air out of his tire!”

And he was... “Sssssss!” It made me feel creepy, ’cause if a man who wanted to get away quick was foolish enough to let air out of his tires, he must be insane.

In another jiffy, the tire had stopped hissing and the guy, still grunting and mumbling to himself, like he was terribly mad, and also maybe a little scared, was down on his knees beside the other back tire and right away there was another hissing noise.

And right that second, the man stood up, and made a dive for the front seat again, zipped in and stepped on the starter, and started to rock the car again, then he backed up, and started forward again, and the wheels started spinning and—

“Hey!” Poetry and I hissed to each other at the same time, “The car is moving! He’s getting away!”

Poetry flashed his flashlight on the back of the car to get the license number, and it was 324–179, and was a Minnesota license. My mind took a picture of it quick, and I knew I’d never forget it, but just to make sure, I kept saying it to myself “324–179, 324–179, 324–179...”

Say, the second that car which was a black newish car was out of that sandy place, it shot down that road like a bullet.

There wasn’t a thing we could do, not a thing, I thought, and wondered if the girl was maybe in the back seat and why on earth didn’t we try to rescue her, if she was there?

We made a dive for the place where the car had been stuck, and studied the road. Poetry let out a gasp and said, “He’s awfully smart, that guy. Look at these wide tire tracks, will you?”

I looked, and Poetry was right. First I looked at how narrow they had been before they got stuck in the sand, and then I looked at them *after* they'd gone on up the road, and they were almost half again as wide.

"Letting out that air, increased *traction*," Poetry said, "but he can't run on them half flat very far or very fast. He'll have to stop at the first gas station that's open, and get some air. Come on! Let's get to a telephone quick, and call the Bemidji and the Pass Lake police and have all the gas stations watch for him. Give them the license number, and I'll bet the police will catch him!"

With that, Poetry whirled around, his flashlight in his hand and we were starting to run up the sandy lane to where the fire warden lived, when I noticed something shining in the grass at the side of the lane.

"Look!" I said, "Shine your light over here a minute."

I stooped over to pick up whatever it was, thinking it might be a scarf pin or something the kidnapped girl might have had, but shucks, it was only a piece of glass. I picked it up, though, and was going to throw it away when Poetry grabbed my arm and stopped me and said, "Hey, wait! Let me see it!"

"It's a piece of broken glass," I said, but let him look at it up close with his flashlight. "Sure," he said, "it's a clue."

"How could a piece of broken glass be a clue?" I asked.

"'Cause it isn't stained with weather or anything, which means it hasn't been lying out here very long," Poetry said, and tucked it in his pocket.

It wasn't any time to argue, but I thought his detective ideas were nearly all imagination.

He was running awful fast for a barrel-shaped boy, and I was having a hard time keeping up with him as we swished along down that sandy lane. We knew the firewarden didn't live very far up that lane on account of we had been here the year before and knew that his house was the nearest one

that had a telephone—Santa not having one in his cabin, on account of not wanting his vacation spoiled by people calling him up. If he needed a telephone, he could always go to where there was one.

“Wait,” I said to Poetry all of a sudden. “Maybe we’re on a wild goose chase, maybe we’re crazy to waste a lot of good sleeping time chasing an imaginary kidnapper. How do we know that was a kidnapper’s car? What if it was just *anybody* who got stuck in the sand? He wouldn’t appreciate having policemen stop him and ask a lot of questions!”

“It wasn’t just *anybody*!” Poetry said. “That guy was down there in the boathouse less than a half hour ago, and there was a girl there, too, see?”

Poetry stopped long enough to pull out of his pocket and show me something he had picked up back there where the car had been, and it was a girl’s yellow scarf!

“But that could be any woman’s or any girl’s scarf,” I said.

“It *could* not,” Poetry disagreed with me with a very sure voice, and also an excited one, “—see that green paint on it—and look! Here’s some white paint also.” Well, I remembered Santa had been using green and white paint in that boathouse that very afternoon, and remembering that put wings on my feet, and I ran like a deer up that winding sandy road toward the firewarden’s house and the telephone.

9

IF anybody had seen Poetry and me swishing along down that narrow winding road, following along in the bobbing path of our flashlights, our breath coming in quick short pants, they might have thought we were crazy. It was one of the crookedest roads I'd ever seen in my life, and would you believe it, Poetry couldn't resist puffing a part of a poem as we raced along toward the firewarden's cabin. The poem started out like this:

“There was a crooked man, he walked a crooked mile;
He found a crooked six-pence beside a crooked style—”

Only we didn't find any six-pence, but we did find something else, and in a fast jiffy I'll tell you what it was. In a half minute more we knew we would be ready to turn the last bend in the road just before we got to the firewarden's house. All of a sudden Poetry stopped and flashed his light about fifty yards down the road ahead of us, and as plain as day I saw a great big beautiful reddish-brown deer standing right in the center of the road. Its head was up and his big antlers looked very pretty. His ears were large and were spread out like our old Brindle cow back home spreads hers out when she is interested in something, or scared. Say, that deer was *really* scared. It turned and like a reddish-brown flash it was gone, leaping away and disappearing into the trees and bushes at the side of the road. It's a good thing we saw the deer, though, 'cause if we hadn't maybe we wouldn't have stopped and wouldn't have heard what we heard right that second. We both heard it at the same time, and it sounded exactly like what we'd heard before when we were standing out by the wood rick.

“It's another screech owl,” Poetry said, and started on, but I stopped him, and said, “Maybe it's a loon.”

“It’s coming from out there in the trees,” he said. “Loons don’t stay up here in the woods. They’re out on the lake or else right close to it all the time.”

We both listened, my heart thumping like Pop’s hammer driving a terribly big nail into a log in our barn at Sugar Creek. It was a worse scare than I’d had in a long time. It certainly sounded exactly like what we’d heard at the boathouse. I remembered the simpish looking owl we’d seen standing in the hole of the hollow tree behind the boathouse and how it had flown away, but this time I just *knew* it wasn’t any owl or any loon.

“Let’s go see,” Poetry said, and I said, “What if it *is* the girl? What’ll we do? What’ll—”

“Let’s decide later,” Poetry interrupted me by saying. We flashed our lights out toward the trees and couldn’t see a thing, but we heard that eery cry that was like a loon being choked, and then we started toward it, our lights shoving the dark back as we went along, and we walked in their yellowish bobbing paths.

We crept up slowly. I had a big stick in my hands, ready to use it as a club if I had to. For some reason we didn’t stop to think that maybe we ought to get to the firewarden’s house first, and tell him, but instead we just kept right on going, the pine needles on the ground making a spooky noise under our shoes and, then, all of a sudden, Poetry stopped, and I, who had been following him, bumped into him.

“Look! There’s an Indian blanket with somebody wrapped up in it,” meaning a blanket of many colors like most all families in Sugar Creek have in their homes.

Then I heard it again, a low half-muffled half cry, and we knew we’d found the kidnapped Ostberg girl.

Say, when I looked down at that blanket with the little five-year-old girl wrapped in it, and saw the great big handkerchief the kidnapper had stuffed into her mouth as a gag to keep her from talking or screaming, and as we unwrapped her and saw that her hands were tied together and also her feet

so she couldn't walk, and when I saw the pretty yellowish all-tangled-up hair around her face and shoulders, I forgot all about having been half scared to death a while ago, and got a terribly angry feeling inside that made me want to find the kidnapper and for just about three minutes turn loose both of my fiery-tempered fists on his chin and nose and stomach and literally knock the living daylights out of him.

My pop had told me true stories about how there are wicked men in the world who don't have any respect for God or girls or women, and how every one of them ought to be locked up somewhere until a doctor can get them cured, or else they should stay in jail for life or be executed for their awful crimes, which means they ought to be put to death in the electric chair or hung, Pop says. Anyway, there ought not to be even one of them allowed to run free in this world, and if they are allowed to, it's the law's or the people's fault.

Well, we couldn't stand there just staring and wasting good temper on something we couldn't help, but ought to get the firewarden quick and he would know what to do.

Poetry certainly had presence of mind. "Take my flashlight," he ordered me, and almost before I could get it into my hand, he was stooped over and taking the gag out of the girl's mouth, and with his pocket-knife was cutting the cords that were around her wrists and hands.

It was pitiful the way that pretty little girl, who was about three or four years younger than Little Jim, sobbed and cried when we got the gag out of her mouth. She had a terribly scared look in her face. "H-E-L-P!" she half cried, but in a very muffled hoarse voice, like she had been crying for a terribly long time and had worn her vocal cords out.

"Mama! Mama!" she cried. "I want my M-M-Mama!" Then she would just go into a kinda hysterical sobbing and we couldn't hear a word she was saying.

"We're your friends," we tried to tell her, "we've come to rescue you. We'll help you get to the firewarden's house, and——"

But the poor little thing was so scared that she couldn't say a word we could understand, except she wanted her mama. She was also so weak she couldn't stand up and wouldn't be able to walk the rest of the way to the firewarden's house, and we didn't think we ought to try to carry her.

We had to do something quick, though 'cause she probably needed a doctor, too, so Poetry made me go on the run for the firewarden, while he stayed with the helpless girl. He would yell to us when we came back and flash his light so we could know where he and the girl were.

I tell you I *ran*, but I was trembling so much that it was hard for me to keep going.

In a few jiffies I came in sight of some white birch saplings which criss-crossed each other, making a homemade gate. I could see the house just beyond and an old unpainted barn. Also, there was a light in the window of what looked like an ordinary bungalow which meant that maybe the firewarden was still up, not having gone to bed yet.

I lay down and squished myself under that gate, and in a hurried jiffy was knocking at the door of the bungalow.

"Quick!" I panted as soon as the door opened. "We've found the kidnapped Ostberg girl! She's out there in the trees wrapped up in an Indian blanket and——" and for some reason, right that second, I remembered about the automobile and its license number. I half yelled the things I wanted to say. The firewarden looked ridiculous in his green-striped pajamas as he stood in the doorway of his kitchen, with a flashlight in his hand.

"What is it?" a woman's voice called from somewhere back in the house. It was the voice of a sleepy woman who had just woke up and wanted to know what was going on.

"Quick!" I said. "The auto license number is Minnesota 324-179, and he's got two half-flat tires and will have to stop somewhere at an oil station and get some air."

I guess maybe the firewarden must have known all about the Ostberg girl having been kidnapped 'cause it only took me a little while to explain enough to him so he was ready for action. He was a kind of an oldish man but he was very spry and could think fast. While his wife was dressing somewhere in the house, he made two quick phone calls, and almost right away he got his powerful electric lantern and the three of us were on our way to his home-made gate. There we stopped while he flashed his flashlight around a little and said, "Well, what do you know—he must have thought our driveway was another bend in the road. He started to turn in, then swung out again. See?"

I used my own flashlight on the tire tracks, and, as plain as day, I saw that some car had made a sharp turn there, and as sure as the nose on Dragonfly's face, which, as you maybe know, turns south at the end, I noticed that the back tires had wider patterns than the front.

We zipped up to where Poetry was waiting for us with the kidnapped girl. That pretty little girl was still so scared that she couldn't talk without great sobs getting mixed up with her words, and you couldn't understand her very well. Say, the firewarden's wife just knelt down on the ground beside that tangled-up-golden-haired little pretty-faced girl and gathered her into her arms and crooned to her like she was her very own little girl, then stood up with her, and, being a very strong woman, wouldn't let her husband carry her but carried her herself, and crooned to her all the way back to their cabin.

When we had first got to where Poetry was, though, I noticed he was standing beside the crying little girl, with a little book in one hand and was shining his flashlight on its pages and was reading something. "What on earth?" I thought, and waited for a chance to ask him what he was doing and why.

On the way to the cabin, while I was wishing the rest of the gang was there, and thinking that we'd have some wonderful stories to tell that would be even better than Paul Bunyan stories, and also could tell our folks the same ones, I said to Poetry, "What were you doing back there—reading stories to her to keep her quiet?"

“It’s a secret,” he said. “I’ll tell you tomorrow,—or anyway later...”

Well, I’ve got to step on the gas with this story. Almost right away, we came to the birch-sapling gate. There we stood while I showed Poetry where the kidnapper had started to turn in and then made a sharp turn and gone on. Poetry flashed his flashlight down real close to the ground and studied the patterns of the tracks and said, “He must have slowed down a lot right here, or the tire patterns wouldn’t be so plain.”

Right that second there were the headlight and also a spotlight of a car swinging down the road coming toward us real fast. “It’s the police already,” the firewarden said, and sure enough it was.

Say, there was certainly some excitement around there and also on the inside of me for awhile.

First, they made sure the girl was all right. In fact, Mrs. Firewarden was in the back seat of their car with the girl in her arms and the girl was asleep. In another few minutes an ambulance was coming to take her to a hospital.

“How’d you get here so quick?” Poetry asked one of the big blue-suited policemen, and he answered in a pleasant voice, like he thought a boy’s questions were as important as a grown-up’s, and this is what he said, “We have a radio in our car. We were only a few miles up the highway when the order came through, and so, here we are!”

Even before he had finished saying what he was saying, I was thinking how absolutely silly it is for anybody to think he can commit a crime and not get caught and punished, even though they hadn’t maybe caught the kidnapper yet.

In the next seventeen minutes I saw one of the most interesting things I’d ever seen in my life, and it made me even more sure than I was that anybody—man or boy or even a woman or girl—was just plumb crazy to try to be smarter than the law is and get by with any kind of a crime or sin.

I whispered it to Poetry when I saw what the policemen were doing right that minute, saying, “Anybody can’t get by with any kind of crime,” and

Poetry, who is almost as good a Christian as Little Jim is, and who not only has a lot of poems on the tip of his tongue ready to be quoted any second, but also knows many Bible verses, quoted one of them to me right that minute instead of a poem, and it was, “Be not deceived; God is not mocked: for whatsoever man soweth, that shall he also reap,” and he added to it another which was, “It is appointed unto men once to die, and after this the judgment.”

One of the cops heard him and looked up from what he was doing and said, “That’s right, son; that’s what my mother used to say.”

Then we quit talking, almost, and in the light of his spotlight from his car, watched what was going on. “What in the world?” I thought when I saw the policeman take what looked like a fishing-tackle box out of his car, carry it to the gate and set it down. Then he went back to the car and brought out something else. “What’s that?” Poetry wanted to know, and the friendly cop said, “A flash-bulb camera with a reversible tripod. We’re going to snap a picture of these tire tracks.”

“Why?” I thought, but didn’t want to seem dumb enough to say so, ’cause I supposed Poetry knew.

First, the cop laid a black cardboard down alongside of the tire track, the edge of the cardboard looking like a ruler with little white inch marks on it. Then he set up his camera with its lens focused right straight down on the track. As quick as a wink, there was a blinding flash of light which showed me that it was a flashlight picture they were taking.

Right away, he opened the fishing-tackle-box-looking kit and took out what looked like a Flit can, like the kind Mom uses on flies and also on bugs and stuff in our garden, and began to spray something very carefully all over the track for about two feet of it, holding the spray gun about three feet high.

“It’s shellac,” the policeman said, and I said, “Why?” and he said, “Wait and see,” which I had to do.

Pretty soon, he stopped spraying, screwed off the container at the bottom of the spraying device and screwed on another can of something else and started in doing the same thing, pumping away very carefully, not letting the spray strike very hard on the sandy tracks, so as not to make any of the sand move.

I looked at the other things in the kit which was spread wide open in front of us, and saw what looked like a large salt shaker like the one Mom uses when she is cooking raw fried potatoes, also there was a cup made out of rubber, two other containers, a spoon and what is called a spatula, which looked like a long flat stick our doctor uses when he looks into my throat and makes me say “Ah,” and also looks at my tongue and the place where my tonsils used to be.

“The dry shellac makes the tire impression firm enough to stand the weight of the plaster of Paris without crumbling it,” the policeman said, and even though I didn’t understand what it was all about or why, it was very interesting to watch. Right away he started getting the plaster of Paris ready.

It was certainly an interesting sight. They mixed some of the plaster of Paris in the rubber cup, doing it almost exactly like I had seen our Sugar Creek dentist do it, and also like we do it in school when we make an art plaque or something. The only difference was, they sprinkled in a little salt to make it harden quicker. The plaster of Paris was poured on the top of the water, and allowed to sink to the bottom of the rubber cup until the water couldn’t take any more, then it was stirred with a spoon, and very carefully dipped out with the spoon into the tire impressions. First, though, they made a little cardboard wall along the side of the track so the plaster of Paris wouldn’t run over the edges.

“What’s he doing now?” I said to Poetry, when some sticks and twigs and little pieces of string were laid on top of the first layer of plaster of Paris.

“I don’t know,” Poetry said, “reinforcing it, maybe,” which, it turned out, he was. Right away another thicker layer of plaster of Paris was put on, and then it was ready to let harden.

After awhile, when they were sure it was solid, they would just lift it up and there would be a perfect plaster cast, a foot and a half long, of the tire marks, which, whenever they found the kidnapper's car, would help them prove that he was really guilty.

We couldn't stay there all night, though, 'cause tomorrow the gang had a lot of things to do and see, and besides when a boy wants to be in good health, he has to have plenty of sleep at night, so the firewarden decided to drive us back to camp, while the police looked all around the place where we'd found the little girl, and also in Santa's boathouse for other clues. We gave them the yellow scarf with the paint on it, and went with the firewarden back to our camp to try to get some excited sleep.

Boy oh boy, it had been a great experience! About an hour later, after waking up all the gang and telling them the news, we were in our tents again ready to sleep. The big hot round rock in the pail in the center of the tent certainly had helped keep the tent warm, and when I was in my sleeping bag again, as warm as toast, I felt that I had really done something important in life... Before I went to sleep again, I got to thinking about that little kidnapped girl, knowing how glad her parents would feel when they got the news which they maybe already had, and were maybe already on their way up here to see her. Of course, if she was really sick, and had been mistreated terribly by the kidnapper, she would maybe have to be in the hospital quite a while.

For a few minutes just before I dropped off to sleep, I was listening to the waves lapping against our sandy shore, and was thinking and thinking and thinking. I knew that if I had been up and was standing by the shore looking out on the moonlit water, the rolling waves would maybe look just like our oats field does down along Sugar Creek when the wind is blowing ... waving and waving and rolling and rolling and rolling and looking very wonderful; and for a minute I could see my pop sitting up on our big binder, driving along, and maybe singing a song which nearly always, when Pop sang or whistled, was a hymn we used in our church.... It might be the one that goes:

“Bringing in the sheaves,
Bringing in the sheaves,
We shall come rejoicing
Bringing in the sheaves ...”

Then I remembered Poetry’s Bible verse and it was, “Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap”.... It was absolutely silly, I thought again, for anybody to sow a lot of sin in his life and not expect to reap a harvest of the same kind, and the verse also said God couldn’t be mocked, which maybe meant that every man would be punished for living a sinful life. Then I imagined different things, such as Pop saying to Mom, “I wonder how Bill is getting along up North,” and Mom would say, “Oh fine—I hope. I wonder if he is warm enough. It gets so cold up there at night, and you know how he is—he kicks the covers off in his sleep, and lies there and half freezes without even waking up.” And Pop would remember that I had my sleeping bag, and Mom would sigh and they’d go to sleep. They really were wonderful parents, I thought ... and the waves of the blue water lake rolled and rolled and tossed around some, and then a great big pair of horns stuck themselves up out of the lake, and then a cow’s face, and then a whole cow splashed and splashed, and the water turned all blue all around the big blue cow and Mom tried to stop him from swishing around so much on account of he was splashing around in her washing machine and getting too much bluing on her clothes...

And then I guess I must have dropped off to sleep, ’cause the next thing I knew it was morning and the gang was making a lot of boys’ noise and we had another wonderful day in which to live and have new adventures.

Ho hum, here I am, with all the pages filled up and not even room to tell you about how the kidnapper got away from the police and how the Sugar Creek Gang ran kersmack onto his trail all by themselves the very next day, and what a fierce fight we had and everything. But just as quick as I can, I’ll get going on that exciting story, which was maybe the most exciting experience that ever happened to us. Maybe I’ll get started writing tomorrow.

The End

With the passing of summer many of the Sugar Creek creatures disappear. Gone are the birds, the snakes and the toads—like Bill's old friend, Warty. But a new member of the gang arrives and before winter is past some very interesting and exciting things happen to him, as well as to other members of the Gang.



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With the passing of summer many of the Sugar Creek creatures disappear. Gone are the birds, the snakes and the toads—like Bill's old friend, Warty. But a new member of the gang arrives and before winter is past some very interesting and exciting things happen to him, as well as to other members of the Gang.

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Transcriber's Note:

Punctuation has been standardised, otherwise the text has been retained as in the original publication except as follows:

- Page 4
handkerchief stuffed into her mouth
changed to
[handkerchief](#) stuffed into her mouth
- Page 11
some of the other girl's chores *changed to*
some of the other [girls'](#) chores
- Page 18
one of the very slendor flower spikes
changed to
one of the very [slender](#) flower spikes
- Page 19
sounded like Poetrys' poetry *changed to*
sounded like [Poetry's](#) poetry
- Page 36
Oh boy, or boy *changed to*
Oh boy, [oh](#) boy
- Page 41
like the windink barefoot-boy paths

changed to
like the [winding](#) barefoot-boy paths

- Page 78
can got them cured *changed to*
can [get](#) them cured
- Page 81
then stood up with here *changed to*
then stood up with [her](#)

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE SUGAR
CREEK GANG GOES NORTH ***

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by

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